

SS1 GOVERNMENT LESSON NOTES

FIRST TERM

1. Meaning, Nature and Scope of Government
2. Basic Concepts of Government: Power, Authority, Legitimacy, Sovereignty
3. Basic Principles of Government: Rule of Law, Separation of Powers, Checks and Balances
4. Types and Characteristics of Government: Unitary, Federal Confederal
5. MID TERM EXAMINATION
6. Systems of Government: Parliamentary, and Presidential.
7. MID TERM BREAK
8. Political Ideologies: Capitalism, Socialism, Communism, Fascism
9. Constitution: Meaning, Sources, Features, Types, Importance
10. Rule of Law and its Limitations
11. Revision
12. Examination

WEEK ONE: MEANING, NATURE AND SCOPE OF GOVERNMENT

Meaning of Government

The term "government" can be defined from different perspectives:

- 1. As an Institution of the State:**

Government refers to the structure and machinery through which the will of the state is formulated, expressed, and realised. It includes institutions such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary.

- 2. As a Process or Act of Governing:**

Government also denotes the act of ruling or governing. It involves the process of making laws, enforcing them, and adjudicating disputes.

- 3. As an Academic Field of Study:**

Government is studied as an academic discipline that examines the systems of rule, political institutions, and the behaviour of people in a political environment.

Nature of Government

The nature of government refers to its essential characteristics and how it functions. These include:

- 1. Sovereignty**

Sovereignty refers to the supreme and ultimate power that a government possesses to make laws, enforce them, and govern within its territory without interference from external bodies. This means the government has the highest authority over all persons and institutions within the state. For instance, in Nigeria, only the Nigerian government has the right to legislate for the entire country. Sovereignty also implies independence; no other nation or power can dictate to a sovereign government how to manage its internal affairs. This characteristic is essential, as it distinguishes a government from other organisations and ensures order and unity within the state.

2. Authority and Legitimacy

Authority is the lawful and recognised right of the government to rule and make decisions for the people. Legitimacy, on the other hand, is the acceptance and recognition of that authority by the citizens. A government has legitimacy when the people believe that its actions and decisions are justified and it rules according to the law and constitution. For example, a democratically elected government in Nigeria enjoys legitimacy because it derives its power from the people through elections. Without authority and legitimacy, a government may face resistance, disobedience, or even rebellion from its citizens.

3. Institutions and Structures

Government does not function in isolation; it operates through a well-organised system of institutions and structures that perform specific roles. These institutions include the **legislature** (which makes laws), the **executive** (which implements laws and policies), and the **judiciary** (which interprets laws and delivers justice). Each arm of government has defined responsibilities, and they work together to ensure the smooth running of the state. These structures provide stability, order, and clarity in governance, allowing for the coordination of various activities that promote development and national progress.

4. Territoriality

Territoriality refers to the defined area or space within which a government exercises its authority. Every government controls a specific geographical region known as the **state**, which includes land, water, and airspace. This territory is where the laws of the government are applicable and where its authority is recognised and obeyed. For example, the Nigerian government exercises authority only within the boundaries of Nigeria and not in neighbouring countries like Ghana or Cameroon. The principle of territoriality ensures that the government's powers and responsibilities are limited to its area of control and jurisdiction.

5. Public Good

One of the most important features of government is that it exists to serve the **public good**—that is, the well-being of all members of society. This includes ensuring peace and security, protecting lives and property, upholding justice, promoting economic growth, and providing essential services like education, healthcare, and infrastructure. A good government does not act in the interest of a few individuals or a particular group, but rather for the benefit of the entire population. When a government prioritises the public good, it gains the trust and cooperation of its citizens, which is vital for national unity and progress.

6. Permanence and Continuity

While government officials such as presidents, governors, ministers, and lawmakers may change from time to time, the institution of government itself remains permanent. Governments may come and go through elections, resignations, or other transitions, but the **system of governance** continues. For example, when a new president is elected in Nigeria, the executive arm of government still exists; only the person in charge changes. This permanence provides continuity, allowing the state to function without disruption and ensuring that laws, institutions, and public services remain operational regardless of political changes.

Scope of Government

The scope of government refers to the extent of its authority, responsibilities, and areas of influence. It includes the following:

Levels of Government

- **Federal/National Government:**

Operates at the national level and is responsible for matters that affect the entire country, such as defence, foreign affairs, and currency.

- **State/Regional Government:**

Functions at the sub-national level and handles issues like education, healthcare, and local security within the state.

- **Local Government:**

Operates at the grassroots level, addressing local needs such as markets, sanitation, and primary education.

Arms of Government

- **Legislature:**

This is the law-making body. In Nigeria, it consists of the National Assembly (Senate and House of Representatives).

- **Executive:**

This arm is responsible for the implementation of laws and administration. It includes the President, Governors, and Ministers/Commissioners.

- **Judiciary:**

The judiciary interprets laws and settles disputes. It ensures justice and the protection of fundamental human rights.

Functions and Activities of Government

1. The government makes laws through the legislature and ensures they are obeyed by enforcing them through the executive and law enforcement agencies like the police.
2. The government ensures peace and security by preventing crime, punishing offenders, and resolving disputes through the police, military, and courts.
3. Government protects the rights of citizens, such as freedom of speech and right to life, through the judiciary and human rights institutions.
4. It provides basic services like roads, schools, hospitals, electricity, and water to improve the living conditions of the people.
5. Government controls and guides the economy by making policies, managing resources, creating jobs, and regulating trade and industries.

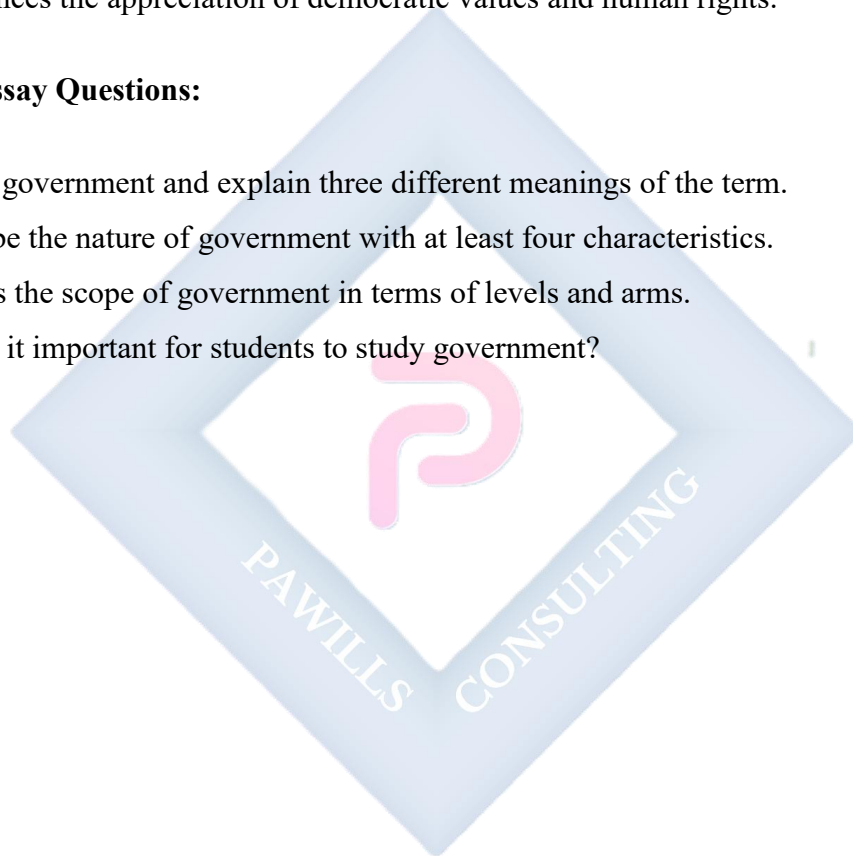
6. It unites people of different backgrounds and promotes national progress through inclusive governance, education, and development programmes.

Importance of Studying Government

- It helps students understand the political system and institutions.
- It promotes good citizenship and political awareness.
- It teaches the roles and responsibilities of individuals in the society.
- It enhances the appreciation of democratic values and human rights.

Evaluation/Essay Questions:

1. Define government and explain three different meanings of the term.
2. Describe the nature of government with at least four characteristics.
3. Discuss the scope of government in terms of levels and arms.
4. Why is it important for students to study government?



WEEK TWO: BASIC CONCEPTS OF GOVERNMENT

Power

Power is the ability of an individual or group to influence or control the behaviour of others, especially in the context of politics and governance. It refers to the capacity to make people act in a certain way, even against their will, through persuasion, command, reward, or punishment.

In government, power is seen in the ability of rulers or institutions to enforce laws, make decisions, and compel obedience. Power can be **coercive** (using force) or **non-coercive** (through influence and persuasion). For instance, the police use lawful power to maintain peace and order. Power may reside in institutions such as the presidency, legislature, judiciary, and military.

There are different types of power:

- Political power – used by political leaders to make laws and decisions.
- Economic power – exercised by those who control resources.
- Physical power – based on the use of force or threat (e.g., the armed forces).

Authority

Authority is the recognised and accepted right to exercise power. While power is about ability, authority is about legitimacy and acceptance. It is when people believe that someone has the legal or moral right to lead or command.

Authority in government is usually backed by law and the constitution. For example, a judge has the authority to sentence a criminal, and a governor has the authority to approve state budgets.

Authority may come from different sources:

- Legal authority – based on law or constitution (e.g., elected officials).
- Traditional authority – based on customs and inheritance (e.g., traditional rulers).
- Charismatic authority – based on personal qualities of a leader (e.g., freedom fighters or religious leaders).

Authority helps maintain order in society because it makes people obey rules not just out of fear, but out of respect and trust.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is the acceptance of the government or leader by the people as rightful and just. A legitimate government is one that is seen as having the moral and legal right to rule. It is usually achieved through popular support, such as free and fair elections, adherence to laws, and respect for human rights.

When a government is legitimate, its citizens obey it willingly, not because of fear, but because they believe it represents their interest. For example, a democratically elected president has legitimacy because the people voted him into office.

Sources of legitimacy include:

- Democratic elections
- Performance and good governance
- Respect for the rule of law
- Cultural or religious beliefs

A government without legitimacy may face protests, rebellion, or lack of cooperation from its citizens.

Sovereignty

Sovereignty is the supreme and absolute power of a state to govern itself without interference from any external authority. It means the government has the highest power to make laws, enforce them, and control all activities within its territory.

Sovereignty includes both internal and external aspects:

- Internal sovereignty is the government's control over its own people and territory.

- External sovereignty means that no foreign country can dictate how the government runs its affairs.

Sovereignty gives the government the power to:

- Levy taxes
- Control the police and military
- Enter treaties with other countries
- Make and enforce laws

In Nigeria, the government is sovereign and makes laws that apply throughout the country. No foreign body can impose rules on Nigeria unless agreed upon through international law or treaty.

Differences Between Power, Authority, Legitimacy, and Sovereignty

Concept	Meaning	Based on	Backed by	Acceptance Required?
Power	Ability to control others	Force/Influence	May or may not be legal	Not always
Authority	Right to command	Law/Tradition	Legally backed	Yes
Legitimacy	Acceptance of rule	Popular support	Moral/legal recognition	Yes
Sovereignty	Supreme governing power	Independence	Constitution	Yes

Evaluation/Essay Questions:

1. Define power and explain how it is used in government.
2. What is authority? List and explain three sources of authority.
3. Define legitimacy and describe two ways a government can gain legitimacy.
4. Explain the concept of sovereignty and differentiate between internal and external sovereignty.
5. Differentiate between power and authority with examples.

WEEK THREE: BASIC PRINCIPLES OF GOVERNMENT

Rule of Law

The **Rule of Law** is one of the most important principles in a democratic society. It refers to the idea that **no individual, group, or government is above the law**, and that **laws must be applied fairly, equally, and consistently** to all persons regardless of their social class, political position, ethnicity, or religion. It is the opposite of arbitrary rule, where leaders make decisions based on personal interests or emotions rather than legal principles.

In a country governed by the Rule of Law, **everyone, including the President, governors, lawmakers, traditional rulers, and ordinary citizens, is subject to the law**. The government must obey the Constitution, and its actions must be lawful. This creates an environment of fairness, security, and predictability, where citizens know their rights and responsibilities and can trust the legal system to protect them.

Key Features of the Rule of Law

1. **Supremacy of the Law**

The law is above everyone and everything. No one, no matter how powerful, can act outside or above the law. The Constitution is the highest legal document, and all other laws and actions must conform to it.

2. **Equality Before the Law**

This means that all individuals must be treated the same way by the courts and law enforcement agencies. For instance, a rich businessman and a poor farmer must face the same punishment if they commit the same offence.

3. **Respect for Fundamental Human Rights**

The Rule of Law protects citizens from oppression, abuse, and injustice by guaranteeing their fundamental rights, such as freedom of speech, freedom of movement, right to a fair trial, right to life, and right to property. These rights are enshrined in Chapter IV of the Nigerian Constitution.

4. **Due Process of Law**

Individuals must be tried according to established legal procedures. No person can be

punished or deprived of liberty without being heard in a court of competent jurisdiction. This ensures fairness and protects against wrongful imprisonment or persecution.

5. Independent Judiciary

The courts must be free from interference by the executive or legislature. Judges must be able to make decisions based on the law, not based on threats, bribes, or political pressure. An independent judiciary strengthens public confidence in the legal system.

Importance of Rule of Law in Governance

1. It limits the actions of government officials and ensures that they act within the law. This helps to prevent dictatorship and tyranny.
2. When leaders know that they can be held accountable by the law, they are more likely to act responsibly.
3. Citizens are more likely to respect and obey a government that applies laws fairly and protects their rights.
4. Rule of Law reduces conflicts and promotes peaceful resolution of disputes through the legal system rather than violence or self-help.
5. Investors and businesses are more confident in a society where laws are clear and disputes can be fairly resolved. This attracts foreign investment and boosts development.

Challenges to the Rule of Law in Nigeria

Despite being a constitutional principle, Nigeria faces many challenges in fully upholding the Rule of Law:

- Corruption in the police and judiciary
- Political interference in court cases
- Delays in the judicial process
- Disobedience of court orders by public officials
- Poor access to justice for the poor and uneducated

These issues weaken the effectiveness of the legal system and can lead to loss of faith in the law.

Separation of Powers

The Separation of Powers is a fundamental principle of constitutional democracy that involves the division of the functions and responsibilities of government into three separate and independent arms: the legislature, the executive, and the judiciary. Each of these arms has its own unique powers and operates independently to avoid the abuse or concentration of power in one institution or person.

This concept was famously promoted by Baron de Montesquieu, a French political thinker, in his book *The Spirit of the Laws* (1748). He argued that liberty and justice can only be protected in a state where these three arms of government are separate and can operate without interference from each other.

The Three Arms of Government and Their Functions

1. **The Legislature (Law-Making Arm):** This is the branch of government responsible for making laws. In Nigeria, the legislature at the federal level is known as the **National Assembly**, which consists of the **Senate** and the **House of Representatives**. At the state level, it is known as the **State House of Assembly**. Legislators debate bills, make laws, approve budgets, and oversee the activities of the executive.
2. **The Executive (Law-Enforcing Arm):** The executive is responsible for implementing and enforcing the laws passed by the legislature. It is headed by the **President** at the federal level and by **Governors** at the state level. The executive includes Ministers, Commissioners, and various government departments and agencies. It also controls the military and police forces to maintain law and order.
3. **The Judiciary (Law-Interpreting Arm):** The judiciary interprets the laws and ensures justice is served. It settles disputes between individuals, organisations, or the government, and determines whether laws or government actions are constitutional. Courts of law—from the **Supreme Court** to the **Magistrate Courts**—form the judiciary. Judges are expected to be impartial and independent.

Purpose and Importance of Separation of Powers

1. **Prevention of Tyranny and Dictatorship:** By dividing power among different branches, no single person or group can dominate the government. This prevents the rise of a dictatorship or misuse of authority.
2. **Checks and Balances:** Each arm acts as a check on the others. This means no one branch can exceed its powers without being challenged. For example, the courts can declare a law unconstitutional, and the legislature can impeach the President.
3. **Promotes Rule of Law and Accountability:** Separation of Powers ensures that government officials act within the law. Each arm is accountable for its actions and can be questioned or restrained by the others.
4. **Encourages Specialisation and Efficiency:** Each branch focuses on its specific role, leading to greater efficiency in governance. Legislators concentrate on law-making, executives on administration, and judges on justice.
5. **Upholds Democracy and Human Rights:** A government with separated powers is more likely to respect the rights of citizens, protect civil liberties, and avoid political oppression.

Challenges to the Principle in Nigeria

Despite constitutional provisions, Nigeria sometimes faces challenges in fully upholding the principle:

- Political interference in judicial matters.
- Executive dominance over weaker legislatures.
- Delays in the judicial process due to lack of independence or funding.
- Occasional breaches of limits by one arm of government into the domain of another.

These challenges reduce public confidence in governance and hinder the effectiveness of democratic institutions.

Checks and Balances

The principle of Checks and Balances is a democratic mechanism that allows each arm of government—the Legislature, the Executive, and the Judiciary—to monitor, restrain, and balance the powers of the others. It is designed to prevent any one branch from becoming too powerful or acting beyond its legal limits. This system ensures that power is distributed and regulated in a way that promotes accountability, protects citizens' rights, and prevents the rise of tyranny or dictatorship.

Checks and balances operate in tandem with the principle of Separation of Powers. While separation of powers divides governmental functions among the three branches, checks and balances make sure these branches remain cooperative and interdependent, without undermining each other's authority.

Purpose of Checks and Balances

1. **To Prevent Abuse of Power:** Power can corrupt when concentrated in one hand. Checks and balances stop any arm of government from becoming dictatorial or overriding others.
2. **To Promote Rule of Law:** It ensures that all branches act within the confines of the Constitution and established laws.
3. **To Encourage Accountability:** When each branch knows it is being monitored, it becomes more cautious and responsible in its actions.
4. **To Strengthen Good Governance:** Through mutual supervision, branches work more efficiently, fostering respect for the rule of law and democratic principles.

Examples of Checks and Balances in Practice

1. The Legislature Checking the Executive:

- ❖ **Impeachment Powers:** The National Assembly (Senate and House of Representatives) can remove the President, Vice President, or Governors through impeachment processes if they are found guilty of gross misconduct.
- ❖ **Approval of Appointments:** The Senate must confirm key appointments made by the President, such as ministers, ambassadors, and the Chief Justice.

- ❖ **Budget Oversight:** The Legislature must approve the national budget before the Executive can spend public funds.
- ❖ **Oversight Committees:** These are used to investigate government ministries and parastatals for corruption, mismanagement, or abuse of office.

2. The Executive Checking the Legislature:

- **Veto Power:** The President can refuse to sign a bill passed by the National Assembly. This is called a **veto**. However, the National Assembly can override the veto with a two-thirds majority.
- **Dissolution of Parliament (in some countries):** In parliamentary systems, the executive may dissolve the legislature under certain legal circumstances (not applicable in Nigeria's presidential system).

3. The Judiciary Checking the Legislature and Executive:

- **Judicial Review:** Courts have the power to interpret the Constitution and declare any law or executive action **null and void** if it contradicts the Constitution.
- **Enforcement of Rights:** The judiciary protects the fundamental rights of citizens and can compel the government to obey court rulings.

4. The Legislature and Executive Checking the Judiciary:

- **Appointment and Confirmation of Judges:** The President nominates judges, but the Senate must confirm them.
- **Removal of Judges:** Judicial officers can be removed if found guilty of misconduct, based on the recommendation of the National Judicial Council and with legislative backing.

Importance of Checks and Balances

- **Upholds Democracy:** It maintains the principle of government by law and not by individual will.
- **Protects Citizens' Rights:** Prevents arbitrary use of power that may lead to oppression.
- **Promotes Cooperation:** Encourages the arms of government to work together, though independently.

- **Ensures Stability:** Creates a balanced system where no one branch dominates, reducing the chances of political crisis.
- **Builds Public Confidence:** Citizens are more likely to trust a government that checks its own powers.

Challenges to Checks and Balances in Nigeria

- **Political Interference:** Sometimes, political influence weakens the independence of the judiciary or the oversight role of the legislature.
- **Corruption:** Bribery and favouritism can undermine accountability.
- **Weak Institutions:** Lack of resources, independence, or courage in some institutions makes them ineffective in checking others.
- **Disregard for Court Orders:** In some cases, government officials ignore judicial rulings without consequence.

Evaluation Questions (Essay Format)

1. What is the Rule of Law? Explain its key features.
2. Define Separation of Powers and outline the three arms of government and their roles.
3. What do you understand by Checks and Balances? Give two examples.
4. Why are these principles important in a democracy?
5. Discuss how Checks and Balances support the principle of Separation of Powers.

WEEK FOUR: TYPES AND CHARACTERISTICS OF GOVERNMENT

Unitary, Federal, and Confederal Systems

Unitary System of Government

A Unitary system of government is one in which all powers of governance are concentrated in a single central authority. The central government creates, controls, and may even abolish administrative units or local governments as it deems necessary. There is no constitutional division of powers between the central and local units; rather, local governments derive their powers from the central authority.

This system is often used in smaller or more culturally homogeneous countries where centralisation promotes unity and administrative efficiency.

Characteristics of a Unitary System:

- **Centralised Power:** All decisions and policies are made by the central government.
- **Uniform Laws and Policies:** The same laws apply across the country without variation.
- **No Constitutional Division of Power:** Lower levels of government act on powers delegated to them by the centre.
- **Quick Decision-Making:** Because authority is concentrated, policy decisions are implemented swiftly.
- **Strong National Unity:** There is often a stronger sense of national identity and control.

Examples of Unitary States:

- United Kingdom
- France
- Italy
- Japan
- Ghana

Federal System of Government

A Federal system of government is one in which powers are constitutionally shared between the central government and component units, such as states, regions, or provinces. Each level of government is co-ordinate and independent within its own sphere of authority. Neither level can unilaterally alter the powers of the other.

Federalism is usually adopted in countries with diverse cultures, languages, religions, or large populations, to allow each region to govern its own affairs while remaining united under a central government.

Characteristics of a Federal System:

- **Division of Powers:** The constitution clearly defines the responsibilities of each level of government.
- **Written and Rigid Constitution:** A federal state usually has a written constitution that is difficult to amend.
- **Supremacy of the Constitution:** All levels of government derive their authority from the constitution.
- **Bicameral Legislature:** There are often two legislative chambers (e.g., Senate and House of Representatives) to represent both the people and the component units.
- **Existence of State Governments:** Each state or region has its own government, courts, and legislature.

Examples of Federal States:

- Nigeria
- United States of America
- Germany
- Canada
- Australia
- India

In Nigeria, the federal government is responsible for defence, foreign affairs, and currency, while state governments handle matters like education, agriculture, and local transportation.

Confederal System of Government

A **Confederal system of government** (or Confederation) is a loose union of independent states or regions that come together for **common purposes such as defence, foreign policy, or economic cooperation**, while retaining their full sovereignty. The central authority is usually weak and dependent on the consent of the member states.

This form of government is often formed through treaties or agreements, and the component states have the right to **withdraw** or **secede** from the union.

Characteristics of a Confederal System:

- **Sovereign Member States:** Each unit remains fully independent and controls its own affairs.
- **Weak Central Authority:** The central government acts only on matters permitted by the member states.
- **Voluntary Membership:** States can join or leave the confederation at will.
- **Decentralisation of Power:** Most powers remain with the component units.
- **Limited Scope of Central Power:** The centre may coordinate defence, diplomacy, or currency, but cannot enforce its will without consent.

Examples of Confederal Systems (Past and Present):

- **Historical Example:** The Confederate States of America (1861–1865)
- **Modern Example:** The European Union (a form of supranational confederation)
- **Senegambia Confederation** (Senegal and The Gambia, 1982–1989)

Although confederations are rare and often short-lived, they demonstrate the desire of nations to cooperate without giving up their full independence.

Comparison of Unitary, Federal, and Confederal Systems

Feature	Unitary	Federal	Confederal
Power Structure	Centralised	Shared between centre and states	Decentralised
Autonomy of Units	No real autonomy	Constitutionally protected	Fully autonomous
Constitution	May be unwritten	Written and rigid	Treaty-based or flexible
Speed of Decision-Making	Fast	Moderate	Often slow
Examples	France, UK	Nigeria, USA	EU, Confederate States

Evaluation Questions

1. Define a unitary system of government and explain three of its features.
2. What is federalism? Mention two reasons why Nigeria practises federalism.
3. Define a confederal system and give two of its characteristics.
4. Differentiate between a unitary and federal system of government.
5. List one advantage and one disadvantage of each type of government.

WEEK SIX: SYSTEMS OF GOVERNMENT: PARLIAMENTARY AND PRESIDENTIAL SYSTEMS

Governments across the world operate under different **systems** that determine how power is distributed, how leaders are chosen, and how decisions are made. The two most widely practised systems are the **Parliamentary** and **Presidential** systems of government. These systems differ in their structures, operations, and relationships between the executive and legislature.

Parliamentary System of Government

A Parliamentary system of government, also known as the Cabinet system, is one in which the executive is part of the legislature and derives its authority from it. The head of government (usually called the Prime Minister) is selected from the majority party or coalition in the parliament and remains in office as long as they enjoy the confidence of the legislature.

This system is popular in many countries that were once colonies of Britain and follows the traditions of the British Westminster model.

Features of the Parliamentary System

1. **Fusion of Powers:** The executive and legislative arms are closely linked; the Prime Minister and Cabinet members are also members of the legislature.
2. **Prime Minister as Head of Government:** The Prime Minister is the leader of the majority party and leads the executive functions of government.
3. **Ceremonial Head of State:** In constitutional monarchies like the UK, the monarch or president plays a ceremonial role, while real power rests with the Prime Minister.
4. **Collective Responsibility:** The Cabinet is collectively responsible to the parliament; if a vote of no confidence is passed, the government may be dissolved.
5. **Frequent Elections Possible:** The Prime Minister can call for new elections or be removed before term completion.
6. **Strong Party Discipline:** Members of parliament are expected to vote in line with their party's position.

Examples of Countries with Parliamentary System:

- United Kingdom
- India
- Canada
- Australia
- South Africa
- Israel

Presidential System of Government

A Presidential system of government is one in which the executive is separate from the legislature. The President, who is both Head of State and Head of Government, is elected by the people and does not sit in the legislature. The President holds office for a fixed term and exercises executive powers independently of the legislature.

This system is widely practised in countries with written constitutions and a clear separation of powers.

Features of the Presidential System

1. **Separation of Powers:** The executive, legislature, and judiciary operate as independent arms of government.
2. **President as Head of State and Government:** The President exercises ceremonial and administrative functions.
3. **Fixed Tenure of Office:** The President serves a constitutionally determined term (e.g., four years in Nigeria or the USA).
4. **Checks and Balances:** Each branch of government checks the other to avoid abuse of power.
5. **Direct Election:** The President is elected directly by the people, either by popular vote or an electoral college.
6. **Non-membership in Legislature:** The President and ministers are not members of the parliament or legislature.

Examples of Countries with Presidential System:

- Nigeria
- United States of America
- Brazil
- Kenya
- Philippines
- Mexico

Differences Between Parliamentary and Presidential Systems

Feature	Parliamentary System	Presidential System
Head of Government	Prime Minister	President
Relationship with Legislature	Fusion of powers	Separation of powers
Method of Selection	By parliament	Direct election by the people
Tenure of Office	Not fixed; based on confidence	Fixed tenure (e.g., 4 or 5 years)
Removal from Office	By vote of no confidence	By impeachment
Examples	UK, India, Canada	Nigeria, USA, Brazil

Advantages and Disadvantages

Parliamentary System

Advantages:

- Promotes cooperation between legislature and executive
- Easier to remove an ineffective government
- Faster legislative process

Disadvantages:

- May lead to instability due to frequent votes of no confidence
- Prime Minister may be too dependent on party support

Presidential System

Advantages:

- Stability due to fixed tenure
- Separation of powers enhances accountability
- President has a national mandate

Disadvantages:

- Risk of gridlock between executive and legislature
- Difficult to remove a failing President
- May concentrate too much power in one individual

Evaluation Questions

1. Define a parliamentary system of government and list three of its features.
2. Explain what is meant by a presidential system and list three countries practising it.
3. Highlight four differences between the parliamentary and presidential systems.
4. Discuss two advantages and two disadvantages of each system.
5. Why do you think Nigeria adopted the presidential system over the parliamentary system?

WEEK EIGHT: POLITICAL IDEOLOGIES: CAPITALISM, SOCIALISM, COMMUNISM, AND FASCISM

A political ideology is a set of beliefs, ideas, and values that guides the political, economic, and social organisation of a society. It influences how governments are formed, how power is exercised, and how resources are distributed. Political ideologies help shape citizens' views on freedom, equality, justice, property ownership, and the role of government in society. The four main ideologies discussed in this lesson are Capitalism, Socialism, Communism, and Fascism.

1. Capitalism

Capitalism is an economic and political ideology that emphasises private ownership of property and the means of production. In a capitalist system, individuals and businesses are free to produce, buy, and sell goods and services in a market environment that is regulated mainly by the forces of demand and supply. The government plays a limited role, usually stepping in only to maintain law and order, protect property rights, and enforce contracts.

The primary goal of capitalism is to generate profit. People are motivated by the desire to earn income and accumulate wealth through entrepreneurship, investment, and trade. This leads to a highly competitive environment where businesses strive to offer better quality and prices to attract customers.

Key Features of Capitalism

1. **Private Ownership:** In capitalism, individuals or corporations own property, land, factories, and businesses. They have the legal right to control and use their assets as they wish, including selling, leasing, or investing them for profit.
2. **Profit Motive:** Economic activities are driven by the desire to make profit. Entrepreneurs take risks in the hope of earning returns on their investments. This encourages innovation, efficiency, and productivity.
3. **Free Market Economy:** The prices of goods and services are determined by the interaction of demand and supply in the open market. Buyers and sellers are free to make transactions without government interference.

4. **Minimal Government Intervention:** The government has a limited role in economic matters. It mainly ensures fair competition, protects property rights, enforces laws, and sometimes regulates monopolies or externalities.
5. **Competition:** Businesses compete to attract customers by offering better products or lower prices. This competition encourages innovation, improved quality, and efficient service delivery.

Examples of Capitalist Countries

- United States of America (USA)
- United Kingdom (UK)
- Germany
- Japan
- South Korea

These countries practise modern capitalism, often mixed with some government regulation and social welfare policies.

Advantages of Capitalism

1. **Encourages Innovation and Economic Growth:** Capitalism promotes creativity and invention, as individuals seek new ways to increase profits. This leads to technological advancements and economic development.
2. **Rewards Hard Work and Talent:** People are motivated to work hard, be productive, and take risks because they can benefit from their efforts through income, profit, or recognition.
3. **Consumer Choice and Freedom:** Consumers have a wide variety of goods and services to choose from. They also enjoy the freedom to buy what they want and from whom they want.
4. **Efficient Allocation of Resources:** Resources are allocated based on market demand, which helps to avoid wastage and meet the needs of society.
5. **Individual Freedom:** Capitalism supports personal freedom in terms of occupation, investment, consumption, and enterprise creation.

Disadvantages of Capitalism

1. **Inequality and Exploitation:** Capitalism can lead to a wide gap between the rich and the poor. The wealthy have more access to opportunities, while the poor may struggle to meet basic needs.
2. **Neglect of Social Welfare:** Because the main focus is profit, capitalism may ignore essential social services such as healthcare, education, and housing—especially for low-income groups.
3. **Monopolies and Unfair Practices:** Without proper regulation, large corporations may form **monopolies**, controlling prices and reducing competition. This can exploit consumers and weaken small businesses.
4. **Economic Instability:** Capitalist economies are sometimes prone to economic booms and recessions, which can lead to unemployment and business failures.
5. **Focus on Materialism:** Capitalism may encourage consumerism and selfishness, with less concern for community welfare or environmental protection.

2. Socialism

Socialism is both a political and economic ideology which advocates for collective ownership and control of the major means of production, such as land, factories, mines, transportation, and natural resources. Under socialism, these key sectors are owned and managed by the government or the people as a whole—rather than by private individuals or corporations.

The central aim of socialism is to promote social and economic equality by ensuring that wealth, power, and resources are not concentrated in the hands of a few, but are shared more fairly across all segments of society. It seeks to reduce or eliminate poverty, exploitation, and class distinctions by making essential services—such as education, healthcare, housing, and employment—accessible to all.

Key Principles of Socialism

1. **Collective Ownership:** Rather than allowing private individuals to own large industries and enterprises, socialism transfers ownership to the public or the state. This does not

mean citizens own everything individually, but that resources are managed on behalf of the people to serve the common good.

2. **Economic Planning:** The government plays an active role in planning and directing the economy. This includes deciding what goods should be produced, how resources should be allocated, and how wealth should be distributed.
3. **Redistribution of Wealth:** Socialism implements policies such as progressive taxation and public welfare to narrow the gap between the rich and the poor, ensuring that everyone enjoys a decent standard of living.
4. **Equality and Social Justice:** One of the key goals of socialism is to eliminate the economic inequalities caused by capitalism. It strives to provide equal access to opportunities regardless of social class, gender, or background.
5. **Provision of Basic Needs:** The state often provides essential services such as free or subsidised healthcare, education, public transport, and housing as a right for all citizens.
6. **Democratic Participation:** In democratic socialist systems, citizens have the right to vote, form political parties, and participate in decision-making, while in more authoritarian socialist states, the government may centralise power more tightly.

Objectives of Socialism

- To **eradicate poverty** and bridge the gap between the wealthy and the poor.
- To **ensure equal access** to basic services and economic opportunities.
- To **curb the excesses of capitalism**, such as exploitation of workers and monopolies.
- To promote **social cooperation** and solidarity over selfish competition.
- To build a fairer, more just, and inclusive society.

Types of Socialism

1. **Democratic Socialism:** Combines democratic principles (e.g., elections, political freedom) with social ownership and welfare. Examples: Sweden, Norway, and other Nordic countries.

2. **Marxist or Revolutionary Socialism:** Advocated by **Karl Marx**, this form seeks to overthrow capitalism through revolution and establish a classless, stateless society (often evolving into communism). Example: former Soviet Union.
3. **Utopian Socialism:** Early, idealistic visions of a perfect society based on cooperation and equality. Proposed by thinkers like Robert Owen and Charles Fourier.

Advantages of Socialism

1. **Reduces Inequality:** By redistributing wealth and providing public services, socialism helps reduce the gap between the rich and poor.
2. **Universal Access to Basic Services:** Everyone is guaranteed access to healthcare, education, and social welfare, regardless of their economic status.
3. **Eliminates Exploitation:** Workers are protected from capitalist exploitation since production is meant to serve public welfare rather than private profit.
4. **Focus on Public Good:** Unlike capitalism, which is driven by personal gain, socialism prioritises the well-being of all citizens.
5. **Social Stability:** With basic needs met and inequality reduced, there is likely to be less crime and unrest.

Disadvantages of Socialism

1. **Reduced Motivation and Innovation:** With profits and competition discouraged, individuals and businesses may lack the incentive to innovate or work harder.
2. **Inefficiency and Bureaucracy:** Government-run enterprises may become inefficient due to poor management, lack of accountability, or excessive bureaucracy.
3. **Heavy Tax Burden:** To fund social programmes, taxes are often high, which may discourage investment or economic growth.
4. **Potential for Government Abuse:** In some socialist countries, especially those with authoritarian systems, the centralised control of resources can lead to corruption or suppression of freedoms.
5. **Limited Consumer Choice:** A planned economy may not respond quickly to consumer demands, leading to shortages and lack of variety.

Examples of Socialist Practices and Countries

- **Sweden and Norway:** Practise democratic socialism, offering free education, universal healthcare, and strong social welfare systems.
- **Tanzania:** Under Julius Nyerere in the 1960s–70s, practised African socialism through the Ujamaa policy, focusing on communal ownership and village-based development.
- **Cuba:** A one-party socialist state with government-controlled economy and free public services.
- **Former Soviet Union (USSR):** Practised authoritarian socialism with centralised planning and no political competition.

3. Communism

Communism is a radical political and economic ideology that envisions a classless, stateless society where all property and means of production are collectively owned. It is considered the extreme form of socialism, differing in that it completely eliminates private ownership and establishes a system where wealth and resources are equally distributed among the people. Under communism, the ideal is that each person contributes according to their ability and receives according to their needs.

Communism was formally developed by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, particularly in their famous work, *The Communist Manifesto* (1848). They argued that capitalism creates inequality by allowing a small group of people (the bourgeoisie) to control wealth while the majority (the proletariat or working class) remains poor and exploited. According to their theory, history is marked by class struggle, and this would ultimately lead to a revolution in which the working class would seize control of the state and establish a communist society.

Core Principles and Features of Communism

1. **Common Ownership of Property:** All productive resources—land, factories, banks, schools, and transportation—are owned collectively by the people or the state on their behalf. There is no individual ownership of such assets.

2. **A Classless Society:** Communism seeks to eliminate social and economic classes. In a communist state, there is no distinction between rich and poor, and all people are meant to be equal in status and opportunity.
3. **Abolition of Private Property:** Under communism, private wealth, inheritance, and business ownership are prohibited. People are not allowed to own businesses, land, or large property for personal gain.
4. **Central Planning:** The government controls all major economic decisions—what to produce, how to produce, and for whom. There is no free market; the economy is centrally planned and managed.
5. **One-Party Political System:** Communist countries are usually governed by a single political party (e.g., the Communist Party), and opposition parties are banned. The state controls the media, education, and often restricts political freedom.
6. **State Control of All Institutions:** The government oversees not just the economy but also the media, religion, schools, and even family life in some cases.

Objectives of Communism

- To eradicate inequality and eliminate the exploitation of one class by another.
- To replace capitalism with a system that guarantees fairness and collective benefit.
- To ensure that everyone has equal access to resources and opportunities.
- To create a society in which selfishness and competition are replaced with cooperation and shared purpose.

Examples of Communist Countries (Past and Present)

- **Soviet Union (USSR)** – the first communist state, established after the 1917 Russian Revolution; collapsed in 1991.
- **Cuba** – a one-party communist state since the 1959 revolution led by Fidel Castro.
- **North Korea** – remains a strict communist dictatorship with state control over all aspects of life.
- **China** – still ruled by the Communist Party, although it now operates a **mixed economy** with capitalist reforms.

Advantages of Communism

1. **Equality for All Citizens:** Communism eliminates class differences and promotes social and economic equality, ensuring that wealth and resources are evenly shared.
2. **No Exploitation of Workers:** Because businesses and factories are owned collectively, there is no exploitation by wealthy employers. Everyone is treated as a contributor to the society.
3. **Basic Needs are Guaranteed:** The government provides free access to housing, healthcare, education, and employment, removing anxiety about survival needs.
4. **Focus on Collective Good:** Individuals are encouraged to work for the benefit of society as a whole rather than for personal profit.

Disadvantages of Communism

1. **Lack of Personal Freedom:** Since the government controls nearly every aspect of life, citizens often lose freedom of speech, press, and movement.
2. **Suppression of Initiative and Innovation:** With no profit motive or competition, creativity and entrepreneurship are discouraged. People may feel no incentive to work harder or innovate.
3. **Government Oppression and Abuse:** Communist regimes often concentrate power in the hands of a few, leading to dictatorship and oppression, especially of political opponents.
4. **Poor Economic Performance:** Due to inefficiency, bureaucracy, and lack of competition, communist economies may suffer from low productivity, poor quality of goods, and frequent shortages.
5. **No Consumer Choice:** People cannot choose the goods or services they prefer. Instead, the state decides what is available, often leading to limited variety and dissatisfaction.

4. Fascism

Fascism is a far-right, authoritarian political ideology that is characterised by dictatorship, extreme nationalism, militarism, and suppression of dissent. It stands in sharp contrast to democracy, communism, and liberalism. Fascism promotes absolute power in the hands of a

single leader or ruling elite, with little or no tolerance for opposition, free press, or democratic institutions.

Although fascism allows private ownership of property and businesses, the state exercises strict control over individual and economic freedoms. Citizens are expected to show complete loyalty to the nation and its leaders, and any form of criticism or disagreement is usually silenced by force.

Fascism first emerged in early 20th century Europe, particularly in Italy under Benito Mussolini and Germany under Adolf Hitler. These regimes used propaganda, fear, and violence to control their populations, and they glorified war and national strength over peace and diplomacy.

Key Features of Fascism

1. **Dictatorship:** In fascist regimes, power is concentrated in the hands of one individual or a small elite group. The leader is often viewed as infallible and above the law. Examples include Adolf Hitler in Germany and Benito Mussolini in Italy.
2. **Extreme Nationalism:** Fascism emphasises absolute loyalty to the nation and often promotes the belief that one's country or race is superior to all others. This often leads to intolerance, xenophobia, and racism.
3. **Suppression of Opposition:** Fascist governments ban other political parties, censor the media, and imprison or kill those who speak against the regime. There is no freedom of expression, and dissent is treated as a threat to the state.
4. **Militarism**
The military plays a central role in fascist societies. The government glorifies war, conquest, and discipline, often using the armed forces to suppress internal opposition or expand territory.
5. **State Control of Society:** The fascist state controls every aspect of life, including the economy, education, media, religion, and even culture. Citizens are expected to obey without question and to sacrifice personal interests for the state's glory.

6. **Propaganda and Indoctrination:** Fascist regimes use propaganda to control how people think. The media, education system, and arts are used to glorify the state and its leader, while hiding the truth from the public.

Examples of Fascist Regimes (Historical)

- **Nazi Germany (1933–1945):** Led by **Adolf Hitler**, who promoted Aryan supremacy, invaded other nations, and orchestrated the Holocaust.
- **Fascist Italy (1922–1943):** Led by **Benito Mussolini**, who introduced fascism to Europe and aligned with Nazi Germany.
- **Spain under Francisco Franco (1939–1975):** Franco ruled as a dictator, suppressing democracy and silencing political opponents.

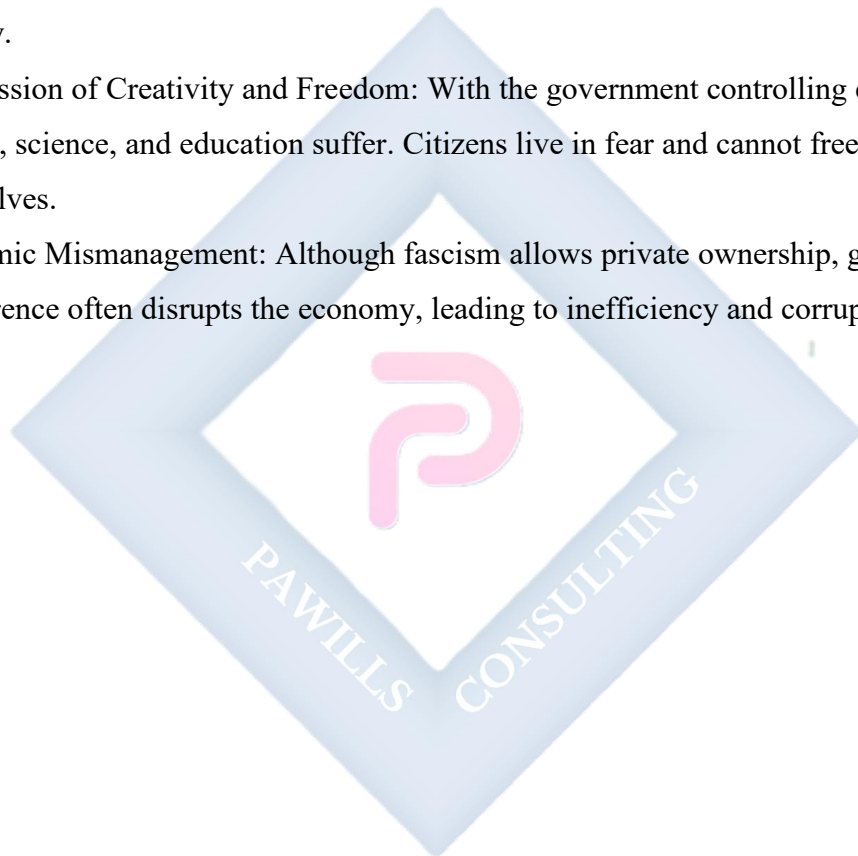
Advantages of Fascism

1. **Strong and Centralised Leadership:** Fascism often brings about strong leadership, which may lead to quick decisions and a sense of national pride and order.
2. **Rapid Decision-Making:** In times of crisis, such as war or economic collapse, fascist regimes can make fast decisions without delay from legislative debates or political opposition.
3. **Unity and Discipline:** Supporters claim fascism brings national unity by eliminating division, crime, and political instability.

Note: These “advantages” are based on the views of fascist supporters and are highly controversial, as they often come at the expense of personal liberty and justice.

Disadvantages of Fascism

1. **Violation of Human Rights:** Fascist governments suppress basic freedoms such as freedom of speech, press, and assembly. Dissent is brutally crushed, and the rule of law is often ignored.
2. **Promotion of Violence and Racism:** Fascism often promotes ethnic hatred, genocide, and aggressive war policies. Hitler's regime, for example, led to World War II and the Holocaust, resulting in millions of deaths.
3. **Destruction of Democracy:** Fascism abolishes democratic institutions, elections, and checks and balances. Power is centralised and unchecked, paving the way for abuse and tyranny.
4. **Suppression of Creativity and Freedom:** With the government controlling every aspect of life, art, science, and education suffer. Citizens live in fear and cannot freely express themselves.
5. **Economic Mismanagement:** Although fascism allows private ownership, government interference often disrupts the economy, leading to inefficiency and corruption.



Comparison of the Ideologies

Feature	Capitalism	Socialism	Communism	Fascism
Ownership	Private	State	Collective	Private (under state control)
Economic Freedom	High	Moderate	None	Limited
Political System	Democracy	Democracy/One-party	One-party	Dictatorship
Class Structure	Unequal	Reduced inequality	Classless	Hierarchical
Examples	USA, UK	Sweden, Tanzania	Cuba, N. Korea	Nazi Germany, Italy (past)

Evaluation Questions

1. Define political ideology and mention four types.
2. List and explain any three features of socialism.
3. Differentiate between communism and capitalism.
4. Who were the key leaders behind the rise of fascism?
5. Mention two disadvantages each of capitalism and fascism.

WEEK NINE: CONSTITUTION

Meaning of Constitution

A constitution is the fundamental law or supreme legal document of a country which outlines the structure of government, the powers and functions of various organs, and the rights and duties of citizens. It serves as a guiding framework within which the affairs of the state are conducted.

The constitution provides the legal foundation for governance. It defines the roles of the executive, legislature, and judiciary, sets limits on their powers, and guarantees fundamental human rights. All laws and policies in a state must conform to the provisions of the constitution, which is often referred to as the supreme law of the land.

In Nigeria, the current constitution is the 1999 Constitution (as amended), which governs the operation of the democratic system.

Sources of Constitution

The sources of a constitution refer to the origins from which a constitution derives its content, authority, and legitimacy. These include:

1. **Historical Documents and Customs:** Some constitutions draw from **past laws, traditions, and customs** that have evolved over time. For example, the British Constitution draws heavily from historical charters like the Magna Carta (1215) and long-standing conventions.
2. **Acts of the Legislature:** A constitution may be **enacted through legislation**, especially in countries with codified constitutions. In Nigeria, for instance, the 1999 Constitution was passed into law by the **National Assembly** and signed into effect.
3. **Judicial Decisions (Case Law):** Courts, especially in countries with common law systems, interpret constitutional provisions, and their rulings contribute to constitutional development. Judicial precedents can become binding over time.
4. **Written Documents:** The **written text** of a constitution itself is a major source. It explicitly outlines the structure and rules of governance.

5. **International Treaties and Agreements:** In some cases, **international law and agreements** influence constitutional development, especially in areas like human rights, trade, or regional integration.
6. **Constitutional Conventions:** These are **unwritten practices** that are followed out of tradition or political agreement, though not legally enforceable. They play a vital role in countries like the UK.

Features of a Constitution

Every constitution, regardless of its type or origin, possesses certain essential features that make it effective. These include:

1. **Supremacy of the Constitution**

The constitution is the **highest law** in the country. All laws, policies, and government actions must conform to it.

2. **Separation of Powers**

The constitution defines the **division of governmental powers** among the legislature, executive, and judiciary to prevent abuse of power.

3. **Checks and Balances**

It provides mechanisms through which each arm of government can **check the powers** of the others to maintain accountability.

4. **Fundamental Human Rights**

A good constitution guarantees the **basic rights and freedoms** of individuals, such as freedom of speech, religion, and movement.

5. **Rule of Law**

Everyone, including government officials, is **subject to the law** as provided in the constitution.

6. **Federal or Unitary Structure**

It defines the **nature of governance**—whether powers are shared between central and regional governments (federal), or concentrated (unitary).

7. **Provision for Amendments**

The constitution usually contains **procedures for its own modification**, allowing it to adapt to changing realities.

8. **Preamble**

Most constitutions begin with a **preamble**, a brief introduction stating the purpose and guiding principles of the document.

Types of Constitution

There are different types of constitutions based on how they are written, interpreted, and applied. These include:

a. Written and Unwritten Constitution

- **Written Constitution**

This is a formally documented constitution where all rules, principles, and laws are written down in a single document. Examples include the Nigerian 1999 Constitution and the U.S. Constitution.

- **Unwritten Constitution**

This type is not contained in a single document, but made up of statutes, conventions, judicial decisions, and traditions. The United Kingdom operates an unwritten constitution.

b. Rigid and Flexible Constitution

- **Rigid Constitution**

A rigid constitution is one that requires a special and difficult procedure for amendment, often involving supermajorities in parliament or a referendum. Nigeria's 1999 Constitution is rigid.

- **Flexible Constitution**

A flexible constitution is one that can be easily amended by the ordinary legislative process. The UK's constitution is considered flexible.

c. Federal and Unitary Constitution

- **Federal Constitution**

Powers are shared between a central (federal) government and regional (state) governments. Each level of government is autonomous in its own sphere. Nigeria, the USA, and India operate federal constitutions.

- **Unitary Constitution**

All powers are concentrated in a single central government, and regional governments, if any, derive their powers from the centre. France and the United Kingdom (despite devolution) are examples.

5. Importance of a Constitution

A constitution is essential to the effective functioning of a state. Its significance includes:

1. **Legal Foundation for Government**

It establishes the legal basis for government institutions and defines their powers and responsibilities.

2. **Guarantees Fundamental Rights**

It protects the **civil** liberties and rights of citizens, such as freedom of expression, equality, and justice.

3. **Promotes Stability and Order**

By providing clear rules and procedures, the constitution promotes peaceful governance **and political stability**.

4. **Prevents Abuse of Power**

The constitution limits the powers of government officials and ensures accountability through checks and balances.

5. **Promotes National Unity**

It outlines common values, national symbols, and collective identity, helping to unify diverse groups within the country.

6. **Protects Rule of Law and Democracy**

It ensures that no one is above the law, and that governance is carried out through democratic processes.

7. Guides Judicial Interpretation

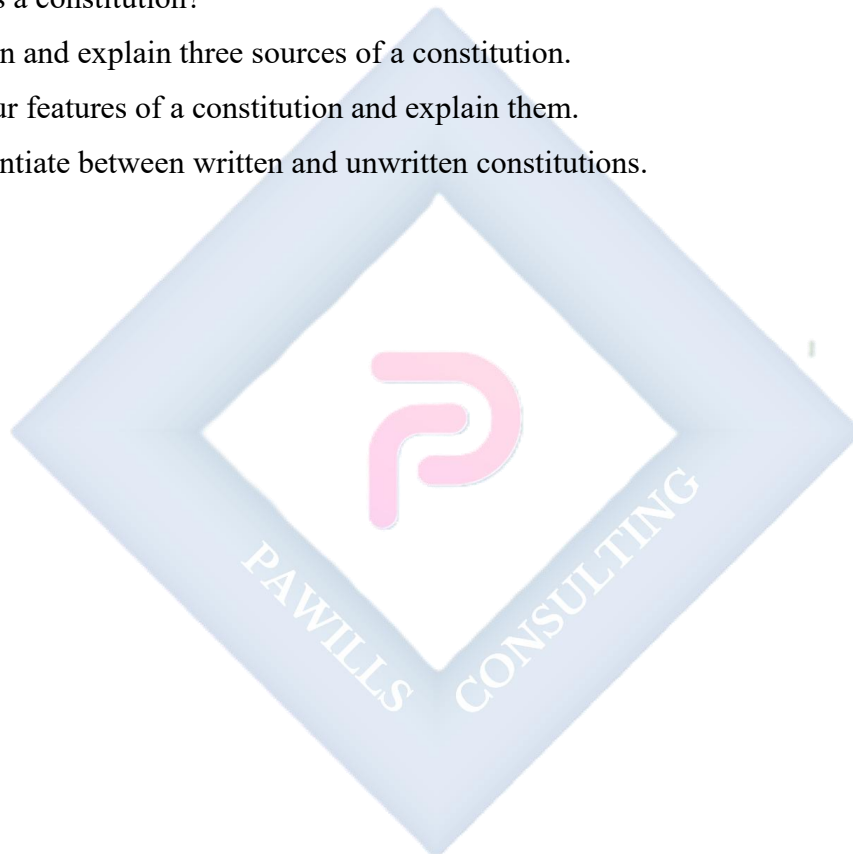
Courts rely on the constitution to interpret laws and resolve disputes.

8. Provides for Succession and Continuity

It ensures that leadership transitions are orderly, especially through provisions on elections and tenures.

Evaluation Questions

1. What is a constitution?
2. Mention and explain three sources of a constitution.
3. List four features of a constitution and explain them.
4. Differentiate between written and unwritten constitutions.



WEEK TEN: RULE OF LAW AND ITS LIMITATIONS

Meaning of Rule of Law

The Rule of Law is a principle of governance in which all persons and institutions are subject to and accountable to the law, which is fairly applied and enforced. It implies that no one is above the law, and the law must be obeyed by everyone regardless of their status, wealth, or position.

The Rule of Law ensures that laws govern a nation, as opposed to arbitrary decisions by individual government officials. It is the foundation of democracy, justice, and fairness, as it guarantees equal treatment, protection of rights, and lawful conduct by both the government and the citizens.

Principles of the Rule of Law

The Rule of Law operates on the following core principles:

- **Supremacy of the Law:** The law is the highest authority, and every individual or group must obey it. No one is above the law, including political leaders.
- **Equality Before the Law:** Every person is equal before the law and entitled to equal protection and benefit of the law without discrimination.
- **Respect for Fundamental Human Rights:** The Rule of Law safeguards the rights and freedoms of citizens, such as freedom of speech, religion, and movement.
- **Independence of the Judiciary:** Courts must operate independently, free from political interference, to ensure fair judgment and protection of rights.
- **Due Process of Law:** Legal procedures must be followed when enforcing laws. An accused person must be fairly tried in a competent court before punishment.
- **Legal Certainty:** Laws must be clear, known, and applied consistently over time so that citizens understand what is legal or illegal.

Importance of the Rule of Law

- **Promotes Justice and Fairness:** It guarantees that all people are treated fairly by the legal system.

- **Protects Individual Rights:** Citizens enjoy constitutional rights and can seek redress if those rights are violated.
- **Ensures Accountability:** Public officials are held accountable and can be punished if they misuse power.
- **Supports Democracy:** It prevents tyranny by ensuring that leaders act according to the law and not personal will.
- **Maintains Social Order:** With everyone subject to the law, it reduces lawlessness, promotes peace, and builds trust in public institutions.
- **Encourages Investment and Development:** Investors are more likely to invest in countries where the law is respected and property rights are protected.

Limitations of the Rule of Law

While the Rule of Law is ideal, its application may be limited by several factors, especially in developing countries like Nigeria. These include:

- **Corruption:** Corrupt practices in law enforcement agencies and the judiciary can undermine justice and the fair application of the law.
- **Executive Interference:** The independence of the judiciary may be compromised when the executive arm of government interferes in court decisions.
- **Illiteracy and Ignorance of the Law:** Many citizens do not know their legal rights and obligations, making them vulnerable to abuse.
- **Weak Institutions:** When institutions like the police and judiciary are poorly funded, inefficient, or politicised, the Rule of Law suffers.
- **Delayed Justice:** The slow pace of trials and legal processes can deny citizens their rights, leading to the saying, “justice delayed is justice denied.”
- **Impunity and Selective Justice:** When some individuals (especially the wealthy or politically connected) commit crimes without being punished, it erodes public confidence in the law.
- **Insecurity and Instability:** In situations of conflict, terrorism, or political instability, the law may be suspended or not enforced effectively.

Evaluation Questions

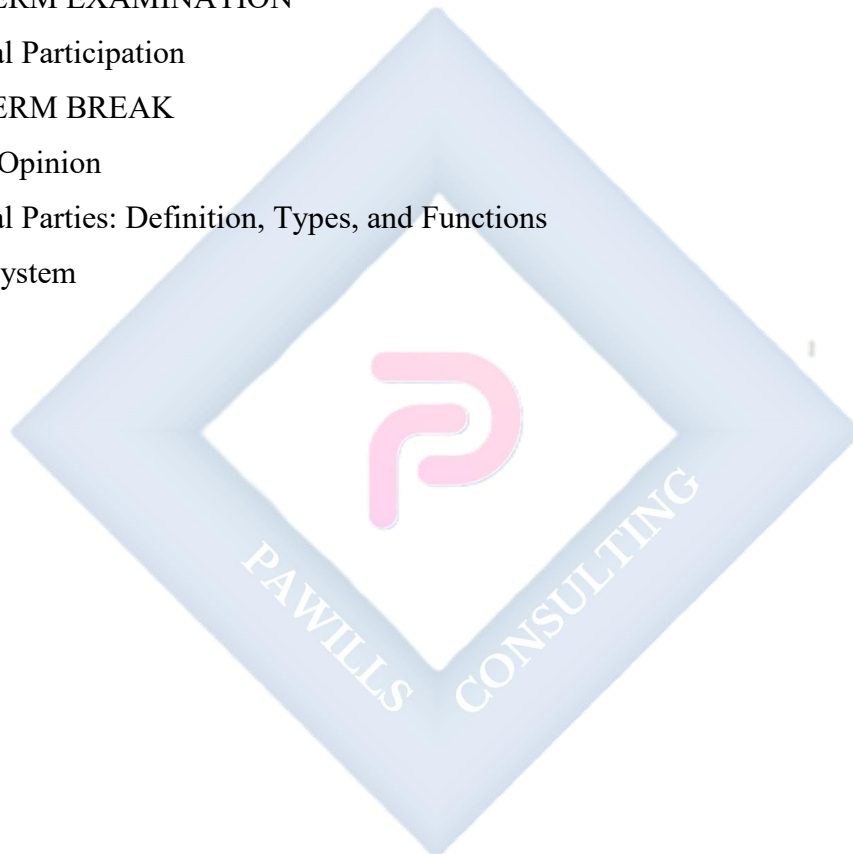
1. What is the Rule of Law?
2. State and explain three principles of the Rule of Law.
3. Identify four reasons why the Rule of Law is important in society.
4. List and explain four limitations to the Rule of Law in Nigeria.



SS1 GOVERNMENT LESSON NOTES

SECOND TERM

1. Separation of Powers and Its Application
1. Delegated Legislation
2. Citizenship
3. Process of Political Socialisation
4. MIDTERM EXAMINATION
5. Political Participation
6. MIDTERM BREAK
7. Public Opinion
8. Political Parties: Definition, Types, and Functions
9. Party System



WEEK ONE: SEPARATION OF POWERS AND ITS APPLICATION

Meaning of Separation of Powers

Separation of powers refers to the division of government responsibilities among three distinct branches—the legislature, executive, and judiciary—so that no single branch holds all the power. This system ensures that each branch performs its own core functions independently, thereby preventing the concentration of power in one arm and promoting checks and balances within the government.

According to this doctrine, the powers of government are separated among three main organs:

- **The Legislature:** which makes laws.
- **The Executive:** which implements and enforces laws.
- **The Judiciary:** which interprets laws and settles disputes.

Each organ is independent of the others and exercises its powers separately to ensure that one organ does not usurp or interfere with the functions of the others. This structure promotes fairness, the rule of law, and prevents abuse of power.

Origin of the Doctrine of Separation of Powers

The theory of Separation of Powers was fully developed by the French political philosopher **Baron de Montesquieu** in his 1748 book *“The Spirit of the Laws.”* Montesquieu based his observations on the British political system of the 18th century, which had evolved to include a monarch (executive), a parliament (legislature), and independent courts (judiciary).

Montesquieu argued that liberty is threatened when one person or group holds all the power of governance, and liberty is best preserved when different organs of government perform different functions independently.

Earlier ideas of this doctrine can also be found in the works of **Aristotle** and **John Locke**, but it was Montesquieu who developed it into a formal political theory.

Arms of Government and Their Functions

A. The Legislature

The legislature is the law-making organ of government. In Nigeria, the legislature at the federal level is bicameral, consisting of:

- The **Senate** (Upper House)
- The **House of Representatives** (Lower House)

At the state level, most legislatures are unicameral (having only one legislative chamber), usually called the **State House of Assembly**.

Functions of the Legislature:

- Making, amending, and repealing laws.
- Controlling public expenditure by approving budgets.
- Checking and overseeing the activities of the executive.
- Approving appointments made by the executive.
- Representing the interests of the people.

B. The Executive

The executive is the branch of government responsible for implementing laws and policies. In Nigeria, the executive arm is headed by:

- The **President** at the federal level
- The **Governor** at the state level

It includes ministers, commissioners, and civil servants.

Functions of the Executive:

- Enforcing and implementing laws passed by the legislature.
- Formulating and executing government policies.

- Representing the country in foreign affairs.
- Maintaining law and order.
- Managing the day-to-day administration of the country.

C. The Judiciary

The judiciary interprets laws, adjudicates disputes, and ensures justice is served. It is the guardian of the Constitution and the protector of individual rights.

In Nigeria, the hierarchy of courts includes:

- The **Supreme Court**
- The **Court of Appeal**
- **Federal and State High Courts**
- Lower courts such as Magistrate and Customary Courts

Functions of the Judiciary:

- Interpreting the laws and constitution.
- Settling disputes between individuals and government.
- Protecting the rights of citizens.
- Ensuring the rule of law.
- Checking the powers of the other arms of government.

Principles Underlying the Separation of Powers

Autonomy:

This principle means that each arm of government—legislature, executive, and judiciary—should function independently without being controlled by another. For instance, the judiciary should be free from political influence to deliver fair and impartial judgments.

Non-interference:

This implies that no branch should intrude into the duties or responsibilities of another. The

legislature should not implement laws (a role of the executive), nor should the executive interpret laws (the function of the judiciary).

Checks and Balances:

Even though the arms of government are separate, they must regulate one another to prevent abuse of power. For example, the legislature can check the executive by refusing to approve a budget, while the judiciary can declare laws or executive actions unconstitutional.

Specialisation:

Each branch is designed to concentrate on its specific constitutional roles—law-making by the legislature, law enforcement by the executive, and law interpretation by the judiciary. This promotes efficiency, accountability, and clarity in governance.

Importance of Separation of Powers

The principle is essential to democratic governance and constitutional order for the following reasons:

- i. **Prevents dictatorship:**
By dividing power among different arms of government, it becomes difficult for any one person or group to dominate the system, thereby preventing the rise of autocratic rule.
- ii. **Promotes efficiency:**
Each branch of government focuses on its specific responsibilities—law-making, enforcement, or interpretation—allowing for more effective and organised governance.
- iii. **Safeguards liberty:**
The principle protects citizens' rights and freedoms by ensuring that no branch exercises unchecked power, thus reducing the risk of oppression or arbitrary decisions.
- iv. **Ensures accountability:**
With each organ empowered to monitor and restrain the others, public officials are held responsible for their actions, encouraging transparency and good governance.
- v. **Encourages stability:**
Clearly defined roles and boundaries minimise institutional conflicts and confusion, promoting order and stability in the political system.

Application of Separation of Powers in Nigeria

Nigeria, as a constitutional democracy, embraces the principle of separation of powers in theory and practice.

A. Legal Basis

The 1999 Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria (as amended) provides for the independence of each arm of government.

- **Chapter I, Part II** establishes the Legislature.
- **Chapter VI** defines the Executive arm.
- **Chapter VII** outlines the powers and structure of the Judiciary.

B. Practical Application

1. The **Legislature** (National Assembly) enacts laws, such as the Appropriation Act.
2. The **Executive**, led by the President, implements laws and manages governance through ministries and agencies.
3. The **Judiciary** interprets the laws and checks the constitutionality of government actions.

For example, the **National Assembly** can summon ministers to explain policies; the **President** may veto a bill passed by the legislature; the **Judiciary** can nullify an unconstitutional law or action by the executive.

However, in practice, political interference, especially from the executive, sometimes threatens the full implementation of this principle.

Advantages of Separation of Powers

a) **Checks abuse of power:**

Since no single arm holds all the authority, each branch acts as a check on the others, making it difficult for any one to dominate or misuse power.

b) Encourages transparency:

The clear separation of duties allows each organ to operate openly within its defined role, reducing overlap, suspicion, and conflict among the branches.

c) Strengthens the rule of law:

With an independent judiciary, laws are applied fairly and equally, giving citizens confidence that justice is not influenced by political power.

d) Fosters good governance:

By ensuring accountability and clearly assigning responsibilities, the system promotes responsible leadership, policy consistency, and effective service delivery.

Disadvantages and Limitations

a) Overlap of Functions:

In practice, the functions of the arms of government may overlap. For example, while the legislature makes laws, the executive (President) must assent to them before they become law, showing that total separation is not always possible.

b) Delay in decision-making:

The need for collaboration and approval among the different branches can slow down important government actions, especially during emergencies.

c) Possibility of deadlock:

Disagreements or power struggles between the arms of government may result in a standstill, preventing progress on key national issues or policies.

d) Political interference:

The executive may sometimes influence the legislature or judiciary, especially through appointments, funding, or political pressure, thereby undermining their independence.

WAEC/NECO Past Questions

- 1. WAEC 2014 (Q4):** Discuss the doctrine of separation of powers and how it is applied in Nigeria.
- 2. NECO 2016 (Q3):** Identify and explain three merits and three demerits of separation of powers.

3. **WAEC 2020 (Q2):** Examine the relationship between the Legislature, Executive, and Judiciary in a federal system like Nigeria.
4. **WAEC 2014 Q4** – What is separation of powers? Explain how it is applied in Nigeria.
5. **WAEC 2020 Q2** – Describe the functions of the three organs of government and explain how their powers are separated in a constitutional democracy.



WEEK TWO: DELEGATED LEGISLATION

Meaning of Delegated Legislation

Delegated Legislation refers to laws or rules made by a body or person other than the legislature, but with the authority of the legislature. In essence, it is a transfer of law-making power from the legislative arm of government (e.g., National or State Assembly) to other subordinate bodies such as ministers, local councils, public corporations, or agencies.

This is done through an **enabling or parent Act**, which specifies the powers and limits of the delegation. Delegated legislation is also referred to as **subsidiary legislation, secondary legislation, or subordinate legislation**.

For example, the Nigerian National Assembly may pass a law giving the Minister of Health the power to make detailed rules on disease control. These rules made by the minister, under the authority granted, are delegated legislation.

Reasons for Delegated Legislation

Several practical reasons make delegated legislation necessary in modern governance:

a. Speed and Flexibility: Parliamentary law-making is usually slow due to procedures and debates. Delegated legislation allows for quicker responses, especially in emergencies like disease outbreaks or natural disasters.

b. Technical Expertise: Some laws require technical knowledge, which members of the legislature may not possess. Delegated legislation allows experts and professionals (e.g., engineers, scientists, or medical practitioners) to make detailed regulations in their fields.

c. Time-Saving: Legislators often have limited time and cannot attend to every detail. Delegating some law-making functions enables them to focus on major policy issues while leaving minor or local matters to others.

d. Decentralisation: Delegated legislation allows local authorities and administrative bodies to make rules tailored to local conditions and needs, which a central legislature may not fully understand.

e. Administrative Convenience: Government ministries and agencies can make regulations that ensure efficient administration of existing laws without waiting for lengthy parliamentary procedures.

Types of Delegated Legislation

Delegated legislation can take various forms depending on the structure of government and the nature of the enabling Act. The main types include:

a. Statutory Instruments: These are regulations made by ministers or government departments under the authority of an enabling Act. They include rules, regulations, and orders used to implement broad Acts of Parliament.

b. Bye-Laws: Bye-laws are rules made by local government councils or public corporations (e.g., transport or water boards) to regulate activities within their jurisdiction. For example, a local government can make a bye-law prohibiting street trading in specific areas.

c. Orders-in-Council: These are made by the executive arm, particularly the President or Governor acting with their cabinet. In some cases, they are used to declare states of emergency or implement foreign policy decisions.

d. Ministerial Orders/Rules: Ministers are often given powers to make specific rules or orders within the scope of their ministries. For instance, the Minister of Education may issue regulations on school accreditation.

e. Provisional Orders: These are temporary rules made pending final approval by the legislature. They are used when urgent actions are needed but await confirmation.

Advantages of Delegated Legislation

Delegated legislation has several merits which support its widespread use:

- a. Efficiency:** It allows swift response to changing conditions without waiting for the lengthy parliamentary process.
- b. Expert Input:** Delegated legislation permits technical experts to make rules that require specialised knowledge, thereby improving the quality of laws.
- c. Reduces Legislative Burden:** It relieves the National or State Assembly from being overwhelmed by minor issues, enabling them to focus on broader legislative concerns.
- d. Flexibility and Adaptability:** Because it is easier to amend or revoke, delegated legislation allows for rapid adjustment to new developments.
- e. Local Relevance:** Local authorities can create laws that address specific issues affecting their communities more effectively than central lawmakers.

Disadvantages of Delegated Legislation

Despite its benefits, delegated legislation also has notable drawbacks:

- a. Lack of Accountability:** Since it is made by unelected officials or bodies, delegated legislation may lack direct democratic control and accountability.
- b. Risk of Abuse:** There is the possibility of misuse of power by ministers or local authorities who may go beyond the limits of the enabling Act.
- c. Complexity and Volume:** The large number of rules and regulations issued can create confusion and make it difficult for citizens to know what laws apply to them.
- d. Limited Public Involvement:** Delegated legislation is usually made without public debate or scrutiny, unlike Acts of Parliament.

e. Weak Legislative Oversight: In practice, parliaments may not effectively monitor all delegated laws, allowing some to go unchecked.

Control of Delegated Legislation

To ensure that delegated legislation is not abused and remains within the limits of the law, it is subject to various forms of control:

a. Parliamentary Control

The legislature may:

- Require that all delegated legislation be laid before it for approval or annulment.
- Use **affirmative resolution** procedures (requiring approval) or **negative resolution** procedures (law stands unless rejected within a time frame).
- Review the scope and use of delegated powers.

b. Judicial Control

Courts can declare a delegated legislation invalid or **ultra vires** (beyond legal power) if:

- It exceeds the authority granted by the parent Act.
- It violates constitutional provisions.
- It conflicts with natural justice or fundamental human rights.

c. Ministerial Supervision

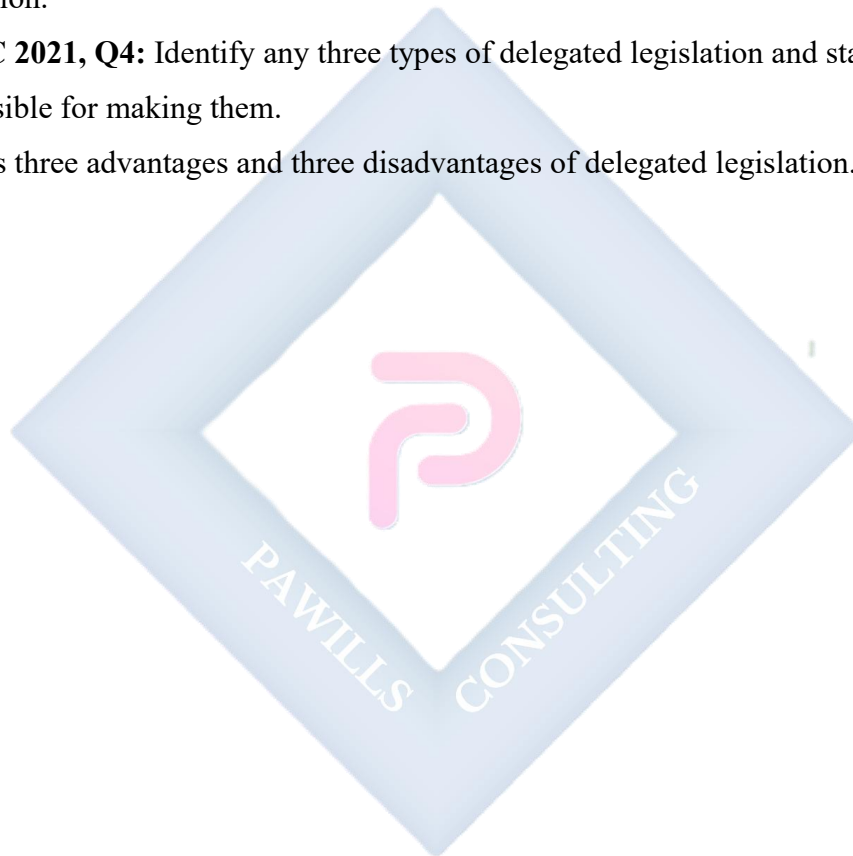
Ministers and senior officials may oversee and guide the work of subordinate bodies or agencies to ensure proper use of delegated powers.

d. Public Scrutiny and Media

Although informal, the press and civil society play a role by exposing unfair or unlawful regulations, thereby compelling review or withdrawal.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2016, Q5:** What is delegated legislation? Explain four reasons why it is commonly used in modern government.
- **NECO 2018, Q6:** Highlight four advantages and two disadvantages of delegated legislation.
- **WAEC 2021, Q4:** Identify any three types of delegated legislation and state the bodies responsible for making them.
- Discuss three advantages and three disadvantages of delegated legislation.



WEEK THREE: CITIZENSHIP

Meaning of Citizenship

Citizenship refers to the legal status or relationship between an individual and a sovereign state, entitling the person to certain rights, privileges, and responsibilities. A citizen is a legally recognised member of a state who owes allegiance to it and is entitled to its protection.

Citizenship is both a **legal** and a **political** concept. Legally, it defines a person's standing in law as a member of a country. Politically, it defines a person's active role in the governance and development of that country.

In Nigeria, the Constitution provides the framework for determining who is a citizen and how citizenship is acquired or lost.

Types of Citizenship

Citizenship may be categorised into different types, including:

a. Birth Citizenship (Citizenship by Birth)

A person is a citizen by birth if either of their parents or grandparents is or was a Nigerian. According to the **1999 Constitution of Nigeria**, anyone born in Nigeria before or after independence to Nigerian parents or with a Nigerian grandparent qualifies.

This is the **most common and automatic** form of citizenship and does not require an application or approval.

b. Citizenship by Registration

This type applies to foreign women who marry Nigerian men, or individuals of African descent who wish to become Nigerian citizens and have fulfilled all conditions laid down by the government.

Applicants must take an oath of allegiance and be of good character. This form of citizenship is granted at the discretion of the Nigerian President.

c. Citizenship by Naturalisation

A foreigner can become a Nigerian citizen by applying for naturalisation if the person:

- Has resided in Nigeria for at least 15 years;
- Is of good character;
- Demonstrates a clear intention to live permanently in Nigeria;
- Has contributed to the development of the country.

Like registration, naturalisation is not automatic and is granted at the discretion of the President.

Methods of Acquiring Citizenship

There are generally four recognised ways of acquiring citizenship:

a. By Birth

This is the most common and automatic method of acquiring citizenship. A person becomes a citizen by birth if they are born in a country to parents (or grandparents) who are citizens of that country. In Nigeria, this applies regardless of whether the birth occurs before or after independence.

b. By Registration

This method is available to certain individuals who are connected to the country, such as foreign women married to Nigerian men or persons of African descent who wish to become Nigerians. It requires formal application and government approval.

c. By Naturalisation

This is granted to foreigners who have legally lived in Nigeria for a long period (usually 15 years), have shown good character, and intend to remain in the country. It is not automatic and must be approved by the President.

d. By Honourary Citizenship

Though not recognised under Nigeria's Constitution, some countries offer honourary citizenship to foreigners who have made outstanding contributions. It is largely symbolic and may not grant full legal or political rights.

Rights, Duties, and Obligations of a Citizen

a. Rights of a Citizen

These are entitlements or freedoms guaranteed to citizens under the law. They include:

- Right to life
- Right to dignity of the human person
- Right to personal liberty
- Right to fair hearing
- Right to freedom of expression
- Right to peaceful assembly and association
- Right to freedom of movement
- Right to own property
- Right to vote and be voted for

These rights are enshrined in **Chapter IV** of the Nigerian Constitution and are known as **Fundamental Human Rights**.

b. Duties and Obligations of a Citizen

Every citizen has responsibilities towards the state, which include:

- Loyalty to the country
- Obedience to laws and authorities
- Payment of taxes
- Defence of the country when required
- Respect for the rights of others
- Participation in civic duties such as voting

- Protection of public property and infrastructure

These duties ensure harmony, national unity, and democratic development.

5. Differences between a Citizen and a Non-Citizen

Citizen	Non-Citizen
Legally recognised member of a country	Not recognised as a permanent member
Entitled to full rights and privileges	Enjoys limited or temporary rights
Can vote and be voted for	Cannot vote or hold public office
Can live and work freely	May require permits or visas
Protected by the country's laws	Protected within limits of residency

A **non-citizen** is typically a foreigner who resides or works temporarily in the country but does not enjoy full political rights and may be subject to immigration regulations.

Loss of Citizenship

A person may lose citizenship under certain conditions, especially when citizenship is acquired by naturalisation or registration. Ways of losing citizenship include:

a. Voluntary Renunciation

A citizen may choose to renounce their Nigerian citizenship if they wish to take up citizenship in another country (especially if dual citizenship is not permitted in that country).

b. Disloyalty or Treason

If a naturalised or registered citizen is found to have engaged in acts of disloyalty, terrorism, treason, or other criminal activity against the state, their citizenship can be withdrawn.

c. Fraudulent Acquisition

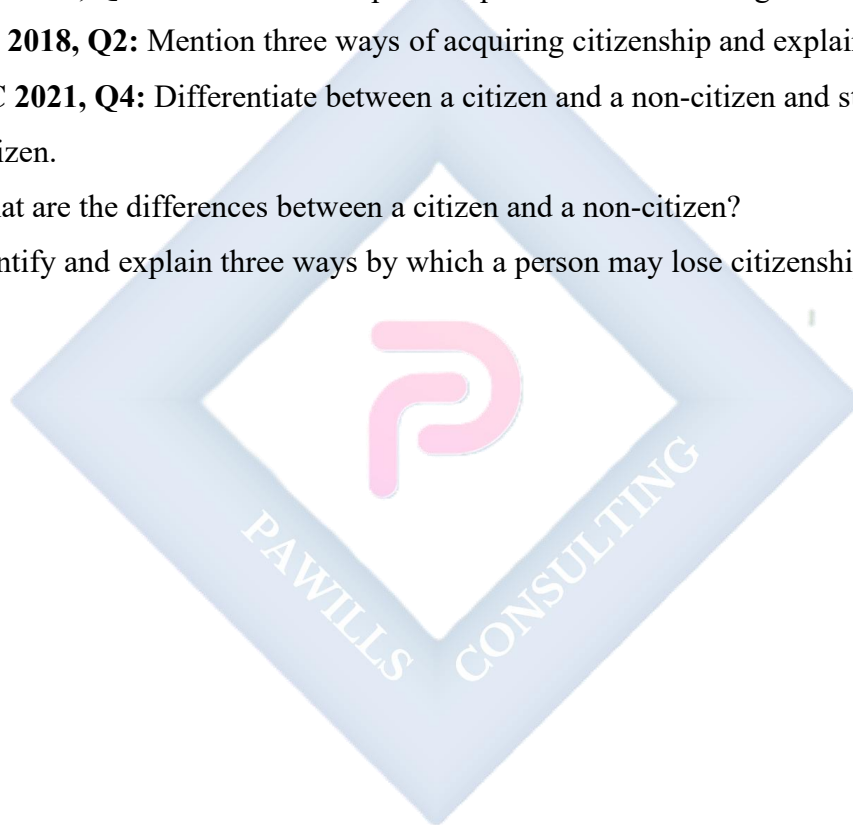
Citizenship obtained through false information or fraud may be revoked by the government.

d. Dual Citizenship Breach

If a citizen of Nigeria acquires another nationality not recognised or allowed under Nigerian law, they may be stripped of their Nigerian citizenship.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2017, Q3:** Define citizenship and explain four duties of a good citizen.
- **NECO 2018, Q2:** Mention three ways of acquiring citizenship and explain each of them.
- **WAEC 2021, Q4:** Differentiate between a citizen and a non-citizen and state two rights of a citizen.
- What are the differences between a citizen and a non-citizen?
- Identify and explain three ways by which a person may lose citizenship in Nigeria.



WEEK FOUR: PROCESS OF POLITICAL SOCIALISATION

Meaning of Political Socialisation

Political socialisation is the process through which individuals acquire political knowledge, values, attitudes, beliefs, and behaviour patterns relevant to their political system. It involves learning how a political system operates, understanding one's role within it, and developing loyalty and a sense of obligation to the nation.

Political socialisation helps people internalise the norms and rules of the political culture in which they live. It shapes how citizens think about governance, leadership, political authority, participation, voting, and civic duties.

It begins from early childhood and continues throughout a person's life, influenced by various agents such as family, school, media, peer groups, religious institutions, and political events.

Features of Political Socialisation

Political socialisation has the following characteristics:

a. Lifelong Process

Political learning begins from childhood and continues into old age. As individuals encounter new situations and information, their political attitudes may evolve.

b. Informal and Formal

It occurs both informally (through family conversations or peer interactions) and formally (through civic education in schools or official government campaigns).

c. Cultural Transmission

Political socialisation transmits political culture—values, ideologies, and expectations—from one generation to the next, ensuring continuity in the political system.

d. Varied Experiences

Individuals may have different political experiences based on their environment, religion, ethnicity, education level, and exposure to events.

e. Influences Political Behaviour

It shapes a person's political orientation, voting pattern, party loyalty, and level of civic engagement.

Agents of Political Socialisation

These are the institutions, individuals, or factors that influence and shape political views and behaviours.

a. Family

The family is usually the first and most influential agent. Children often adopt the political values, ideologies, and party preferences of their parents or guardians.

b. Educational Institutions (Schools)

Through formal instruction, schools teach students about the Constitution, civic duties, leadership roles, and national symbols. Civics and Government as school subjects promote political awareness and national identity.

c. Peer Groups

Friends and age mates, especially in youth and adolescence, influence political opinions and attitudes through discussions and group behaviours.

d. Mass Media

Television, radio, newspapers, and social media provide political news, campaigns, opinions, and analysis that shape people's views on political issues and leaders.

e. Religious Institutions

Religious leaders and institutions influence the moral and ethical dimension of politics. Their messages can shape opinions on justice, leadership, and national unity.

f. Political Parties

Political parties contribute to political socialisation by engaging citizens during campaigns, rallies, and through manifestos that explain policies and ideologies.

g. Government and Laws

Government institutions reinforce political values by enforcing laws, conducting elections, and promoting patriotism through public holidays and national programmes.

h. Professional and Trade Unions

These bodies influence their members' political awareness and promote participation in advocacy and national policy debates.

i. Events and Experiences

Historical and contemporary events—such as elections, protests, civil wars, or national celebrations—can deeply shape political consciousness and identity.

Stages and Processes of Political Socialisation

Political socialisation is not a single event, but a process that occurs in stages, particularly as individuals grow and interact with society.

a. Childhood Stage

At this early stage, children begin to learn basic political ideas like authority, respect for leaders, and national symbols. Most of this learning occurs through the family and early education.

b. Adolescent Stage

As teenagers, individuals become more politically aware and critical. Peer groups, schools, and the media become more influential during this stage. Youths start to form political opinions and may participate in debates and school elections.

c. Adult Stage

Adults actively engage with political processes—voting, joining political parties, campaigning, or holding political office. They also influence others through discussion and civic activities.

d. Re-socialisation or Political Re-orientation

This refers to changes in political beliefs due to new experiences, education, national crises, or exposure to new ideologies. It shows that political socialisation is dynamic and can be reshaped over time.

a. Promotes Political Stability

Political socialisation helps maintain order in society by passing down shared values that foster loyalty, unity, and respect for national institutions and symbols.

b. Encourages Civic Participation

It educates citizens about their civic duties and rights, inspiring them to vote, join political discussions, and contribute to national development.

c. Develops Political Awareness

Through political socialisation, people gain knowledge about how their government works and current political issues, allowing them to make informed choices.

d. Strengthens Democratic Values

It instils core democratic principles like the rule of law, tolerance, accountability, and justice, which are essential for sustaining a democratic society.

e. Shapes National Identity

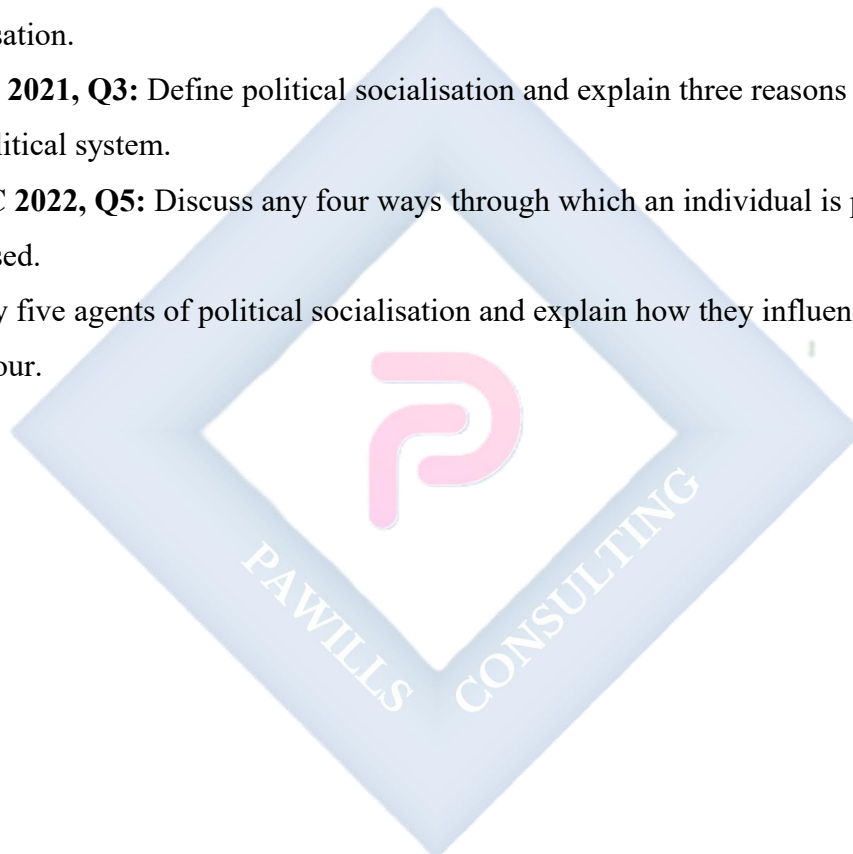
Citizens begin to see themselves as part of a larger national community, promoting patriotism and a collective sense of purpose.

f. Acts as a Tool for National Integration

By promoting shared political values and goals, political socialisation reduces division along ethnic, religious, or regional lines, helping to build a more unified nation.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2019, Q2:** What is political socialisation? Highlight four agents of political socialisation.
- **NECO 2021, Q3:** Define political socialisation and explain three reasons it is important in a political system.
- **WAEC 2022, Q5:** Discuss any four ways through which an individual is politically socialised.
- Identify five agents of political socialisation and explain how they influence political behaviour.



WEEK SIX: POLITICAL PARTICIPATION

Political Participation

Political participation refers to the various ways in which citizens of a country take part in the political process and governance of their society. It includes all actions and activities through which individuals express their political interests, make demands, influence decision-making, and contribute to the selection and functioning of political leaders and institutions.

Political participation is a cornerstone of democracy because it ensures that government remains responsive to the needs of the people. It can be direct (e.g., voting, contesting elections) or indirect (e.g., engaging in political discussions, joining interest groups, or signing petitions).

It enables citizens to exercise their rights, hold leaders accountable, and contribute to shaping public policy and national development.

Forms of Political Participation

Political participation takes many forms, ranging from formal to informal, legal to non-legal. The key forms include:

a. Voting in Elections

This is the most common and fundamental form. It allows citizens to choose their leaders and influence policy direction.

b. Contesting for Political Office

Individuals can run for elective positions such as president, governor, legislator, councillor, etc., depending on qualifications and eligibility.

c. Joining Political Parties

Membership in a political party enables citizens to be part of a structured political process and contribute to its ideology, organisation, and success.

d. Attending Political Rallies or Campaigns

People show support or opposition to candidates or policies by participating in political gatherings and events.

e. Engaging in Political Debates and Discussions

Through social media, television, radio, or informal settings, people share opinions and contribute to political awareness.

f. Protests and Demonstrations

Peaceful demonstrations and protests are lawful ways for citizens to express grievances or demand government action.

g. Petitioning the Government

Citizens or groups may write petitions to express concerns, make demands, or seek redress from authorities.

h. Civil Society and Pressure Groups

Citizens participate politically by joining organisations that advocate for policies, reforms, or the interests of specific groups.

i. Political Education and Advocacy

Engaging in awareness campaigns, civic education, or sensitisation programmes aimed at informing others about their rights and responsibilities.

Importance of Political Participation

Political participation is essential in building a responsive and inclusive political system. Its importance includes:

a. Promotes Democratic Governance

Political participation upholds the principle that power lies with the people. It allows citizens to choose their leaders through free and fair elections.

b. Ensures Accountability and Transparency

Active citizen involvement enables public officials to be questioned and scrutinised. This discourages corruption and promotes open governance.

c. Strengthens Representation

By participating, citizens express their needs and opinions to those in power. This helps leaders make policies that reflect the will of the people.

d. Builds Political Awareness

Involvement in political activities exposes citizens to national issues and decision-making processes. This makes them more informed and responsible.

e. Encourages Political Stability

When citizens are involved in governance, they feel included and respected. This builds trust and reduces the risk of conflict or unrest.

f. Fosters National Development

Citizen participation brings in fresh ideas and collective effort. This accelerates progress in areas like infrastructure, education, and economic growth.

Factors Influencing Political Participation

The level and nature of citizens' involvement in politics are affected by several factors, including:

a. Education

Educated people better understand political systems and issues, making them more likely to participate meaningfully in civic and electoral activities.

b. Economic Status

Individuals with financial stability are more likely to engage in politics, while poverty can discourage involvement due to daily survival concerns.

c. Political Awareness

Civic education and access to political information through media help citizens make informed choices and participate more actively.

d. Age

Young people often engage through protests and social media, while older citizens typically show more commitment to voting and formal participation.

e. Gender

Cultural and religious limitations can restrict women's political involvement in some societies, though awareness and advocacy are gradually improving equality.

f. Freedom and Political Environment

Democratic societies encourage active participation through protection of rights, while fear of persecution in authoritarian regimes discourages involvement.

g. Trust in Government

When citizens perceive the government as corrupt or unresponsive, they may withdraw from the political process out of frustration or hopelessness.

Reasons for Low Political Participation in Nigeria

Despite democratic structures, political participation in Nigeria remains low, especially in voting and party membership. The reasons include:

a. Electoral Malpractices

Widespread rigging, intimidation, and violence during elections discourage people from voting or getting involved in the political process.

b. Lack of Trust in Leaders

Many Nigerians view politicians as corrupt and self-serving, leading to disinterest and loss of confidence in the system.

c. Poverty and Unemployment

When people are struggling to meet basic needs, they prioritise survival over political engagement.

d. Ignorance and Illiteracy

A lack of civic education leaves many unaware of their political rights and responsibilities, reducing participation.

e. Poor Governance Record

When past governments fail to improve lives, citizens become sceptical about the value of voting or political involvement.

f. Ethnic and Religious Divisions

Deep divisions along ethnic and religious lines fuel distrust and limit nationwide political cooperation and participation.

g. Youth Disengagement

Many young Nigerians feel marginalised and powerless within the political system, which leads to apathy and non-involvement.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2017, Q4:** Define political participation and explain four methods through which individuals can participate in politics.
- **NECO 2019, Q5:** Highlight four reasons for low political participation in Nigeria.
- **WAEC 2021, Q3:** Discuss three benefits of political participation and two factors that may discourage citizens from participating.
- Explain four reasons why political participation is important in a democracy.
- Discuss five factors that influence political participation in Nigeria.

WEEK EIGHT: PUBLIC OPINION

Public Opinion

Public opinion refers to the collective views, attitudes, and beliefs held by the majority of people in a society concerning political, economic, or social issues. It is the general consensus or predominant perspective among citizens on matters of public interest such as government policies, political leaders, national security, and social reforms.

Public opinion reflects how people feel or think about issues and plays a vital role in shaping the direction of government actions. In a democratic society, the opinions of the people influence legislation, policy-making, and leadership choices. It acts as a guiding force for political leaders and government institutions.

Public opinion is not static; it can change over time due to events, education, media influence, or leadership behaviour. For example, public opinion on a government's economic policy may shift depending on whether inflation rises or falls.

Formation of Public Opinion

Public opinion is formed through a combination of personal experience, communication, social interaction, and exposure to various sources of information. Key factors that influence the formation of public opinion include:

a. Family

The family is the first source of values and beliefs. Many people adopt political attitudes and preferences based on their upbringing and the views of their parents or guardians.

b. Education

Schools and institutions of learning shape public opinion by teaching civic values, critical thinking, and national issues. Educated individuals are more likely to form independent and informed opinions.

c. Mass Media

Radio, television, newspapers, and especially social media platforms like Twitter and Facebook influence public opinion by providing information, framing issues, and exposing citizens to diverse perspectives.

d. Peer Groups

Friends, colleagues, and social groups influence opinions through discussions, debates, and shared experiences. Youths are especially influenced by peers when forming views on national matters.

e. Religious and Cultural Institutions

Religion and culture affect people's moral judgement and worldview. Religious leaders often comment on political and social issues, shaping followers' opinions.

f. Government Actions and Policies

The decisions and behaviour of political leaders can influence how the public perceives government. A government that delivers good governance earns positive opinion, while poor performance may generate criticism.

g. Events and Experiences

Political crises, economic hardship, national tragedies, or international events can shift public opinion dramatically in a short period.

Measurement of Public Opinion

Measuring public opinion involves collecting data and analysing people's views on specific issues. Governments, political parties, researchers, and media organisations use various methods to gauge the mood of the people. These methods include:

a. Opinion Polls

Surveys are conducted using questionnaires or interviews to find out what people think about a specific issue. For example, before elections, polls are used to predict which candidate is likely to win.

b. Elections and Referenda

Voting results show the preferences of the electorate. Referenda allow citizens to directly express their stance on proposed laws or constitutional changes.

c. Letters and Petitions

People express their views through petitions or letters to government officials or newspapers. The number and content of these letters can reflect the public mood.

d. Media Reports and Editorials

Analysing comments, trends, and editorials in the media gives insight into public reactions to government policies or current events.

e. Protests and Demonstrations

Public gatherings, protests, and rallies are expressions of opinion—whether in support of or against an issue or policy.

f. Social Media Trends

Hashtags, online polls, and public comments on platforms like X (formerly Twitter), Facebook, or Instagram now provide real-time insights into public opinion, especially among the youth.

Importance of Public Opinion

Public opinion is a powerful force in any democratic society. Its significance lies in the following:

a. Guides Government Policy

Public opinion helps government officials understand the wishes of the people. Leaders can adjust policies to align with popular demands.

b. Promotes Democratic Participation

It encourages civic engagement and ensures that citizens play a role in decision-making by expressing their views.

c. Acts as a Check on Government Power

Public criticism of bad policies or corrupt practices can compel government officials to be accountable and responsive.

d. Shapes Election Outcomes

Candidates and political parties depend on public approval to win elections. Their success depends on understanding and responding to public needs.

e. Influences Legislative Action

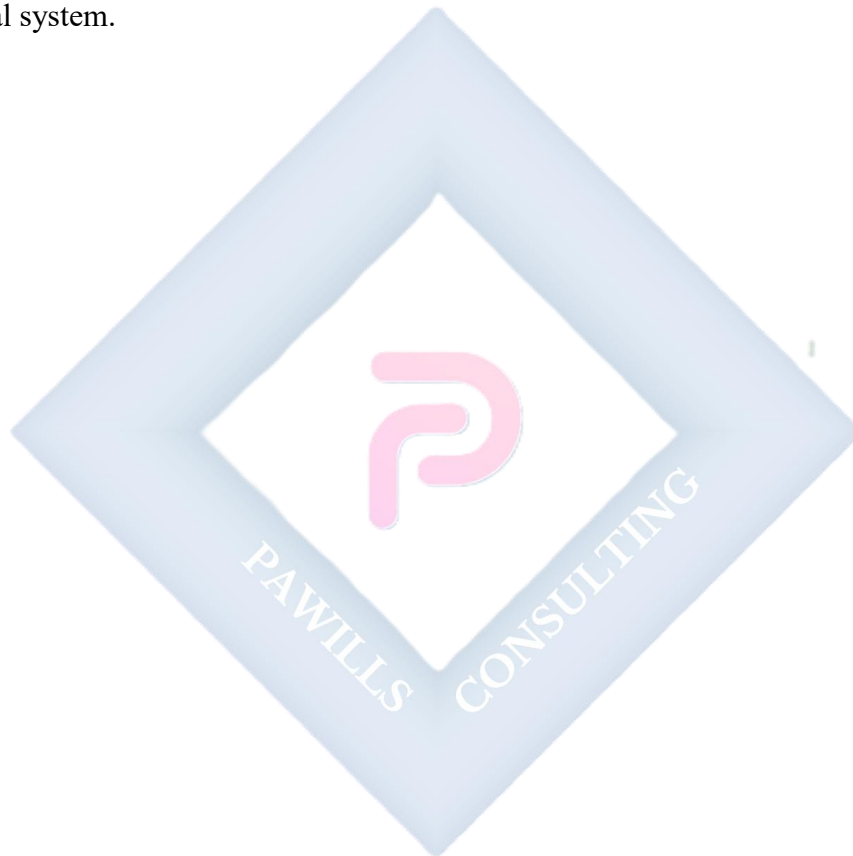
Lawmakers often respond to public opinion when debating and passing laws, especially on controversial issues.

f. Strengthens National Unity and Dialogue

When public opinion is freely expressed, it promotes discussion, tolerance, and collective solutions to national problems.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2016, Q3:** Define public opinion and state four ways of measuring it.
- State and explain four reasons why public opinion is important in a democratic state.
- **NECO 2020, Q4:** List and explain three factors that influence the formation of public opinion.
- Identify three factors that can influence the formation of public opinion.
- **WAEC 2022, Q6:** What is public opinion? Mention four reasons it is important in a political system.



WEEK NINE: POLITICAL PARTIES: DEFINITION, TYPES, AND FUNCTIONS

Political Party

A political party is an organised group of people who share common political ideologies, beliefs, or goals and come together to contest elections and gain political power through constitutional means. Political parties serve as a bridge between the government and the people by representing their interests, mobilising voters, and providing choices during elections.

In democratic systems, political parties perform essential functions such as candidate nomination, policy formulation, and political education. They serve as vehicles through which citizens participate in governance and influence public policy.

Examples of political parties in Nigeria include the **All Progressives Congress (APC)**, **People's Democratic Party (PDP)**, **Labour Party (LP)**, and **New Nigeria People's Party (NNPP)**.

Types of Political Parties

Political parties may be classified based on their ideology, organisation, or membership structure. The common types include:

a. Mass Parties

These parties aim to attract a large number of people, often including diverse groups in society. They focus on broad national issues and promote wide participation. They are usually well-structured and have grassroots networks.

Example: PDP in Nigeria.

b. Caucus (Elite) Parties

These are formed and dominated by a small, elite group of influential individuals. They focus on the interests of the upper class or political elite and may have limited public participation.

Example: Early British Conservative Party.

c. Ideological Parties

Such parties are based on a specific political ideology or belief system such as socialism, communism, or religious doctrine. Their policies reflect their ideological stand.

Example: Socialist Party of Nigeria.

d. Broker Parties

These do not have a fixed ideology but seek to win elections by negotiating and forming alliances with various interest groups. They are pragmatic rather than ideological.

e. Religious or Ethnic-Based Parties

These are formed based on religious or ethnic identity. While often influential in pluralistic societies, they may increase division and tension.

Note: Such parties are discouraged or banned in many countries, including Nigeria, due to the need for national unity.

f. One-Party System

In this arrangement, only one political party is allowed by law. Other parties may be banned or non-existent. The ruling party controls all state machinery.

Example: China's Communist Party.

g. Two-Party System

Only two major political parties dominate the political scene and alternate in power. Minor parties may exist but have little influence.

Example: United States – Democrats and Republicans.

h. Multi-Party System

This system permits the existence of multiple political parties. It provides a wide choice for voters and encourages coalition governments.

Example: Nigeria, France, Germany.

Functions of Political Parties

Political parties play a fundamental role in both democratic and authoritarian systems, though their nature and impact vary. Their major functions include:

a. Political Education

Parties educate citizens on political issues, national policies, their rights, and responsibilities. They use rallies, manifestos, and media to inform the public.

b. Recruitment and Nomination of Candidates

Parties select and sponsor candidates for elective positions at local, state, and national levels. They screen members and present those deemed qualified for public office.

c. Organisation of Government

In democracies, the winning party forms the government. The party in power implements its policies, while the opposition holds it accountable.

d. Representation of Interests

Parties serve as channels through which the people's views and needs are conveyed to the government. They help aggregate and represent various societal interests.

e. Formulation of Policies

Political parties develop and propose policies based on their ideologies and electoral promises. These policies form the basis of governance when the party is in power.

f. Promotion of National Unity

Well-structured political parties cut across ethnic, religious, and regional lines, helping to unite citizens under common political platforms.

g. Opposition and Oversight

Parties not in power serve as the opposition, criticising government policies, offering alternatives, and ensuring checks and balances in governance.

h. Link Between Government and Citizens

Political parties connect the government with the people by communicating citizens' needs and mobilising support for government actions.

Importance of Political Parties in Democracy

- They enhance political participation by giving citizens a platform to influence governance.
- They promote accountability by providing opposition and public scrutiny of government policies.
- They contribute to political stability through structured competition for power.
- They simplify choices for voters by presenting organised platforms and candidates.
- They strengthen democracy by ensuring regular elections, peaceful transitions, and respect for rule of law.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2018, Q4:** Define political party and state four functions.
- **NECO 2019, Q3:** Describe any three types of political parties.
- **WAEC 2021, Q5:** Explain five functions of political parties in a democratic state.
- **WAEC 2022, Q6:** Distinguish between two-party system and multi-party system with examples.
- *“Discuss the roles political parties play in strengthening democracy in Nigeria.”*

WEEK TEN: PARTY SYSTEM

Meaning of Party System

A **party system** refers to the arrangement and interaction of political parties within a country, especially in relation to how they compete for power and influence governance. It includes the number of recognised political parties and how they operate within the framework of the electoral process.

Party systems can vary widely depending on the country's history, laws, political culture, and level of democratic development. The four major types of party systems are: **Zero-party**, **One-party**, **Two-party**, and **Multi-party** systems.

TYPES OF PARTY SYSTEMS

A. Zero-Party System

This is a political system in which **no political party exists or is legally permitted** to function. Leaders are often chosen based on consensus, appointment, or hereditary succession rather than electoral competition.

Features

- No formal political party.
- Citizens may vote for individuals, not party candidates.
- Governance is usually based on traditional, religious, or military authority.
- Common in monarchies, military regimes, or authoritarian states.

Examples

- Some traditional societies in Africa.
- Military regimes such as Nigeria (1983–1993) under Generals Buhari and Babangida.
- Saudi Arabia (absolute monarchy).

Merits

- Reduces political conflict and rivalry.
- Promotes national unity under one leadership.
- May ensure faster decision-making.

Demerits

- Citizens have no political choice or representation.
- No opposition to check government excesses.
- Lacks democratic accountability and transparency.

B. One-Party System

This is a political arrangement in which **only one political party is legally allowed** to operate and govern. All other political parties are banned or unrecognised by law.

Features

- One legally recognised party dominates the system.
- Elections are held, but only candidates from one party contest.
- Opposition is either weak, outlawed, or non-existent.
- The ruling party controls the government and sets all policies.

Examples

- China – Communist Party of China.
- North Korea – Workers' Party.
- Cuba – Communist Party.

Merits

- Encourages unity and stable leadership.
- Quick decision-making and implementation.
- Avoids political instability and fragmentation.

Demerits

- Encourages dictatorship and abuse of power.
- Suppresses dissent and human rights.
- No real electoral choice for the people.
- Lacks accountability due to absence of opposition.

C. Two-Party System

A system where **two major political parties dominate** the political landscape. These two parties alternate in power while other smaller parties exist but are not influential.

Features

- Two dominant parties contest elections.
- One forms the government; the other acts as opposition.
- Elections provide citizens with a clear choice.
- Promotes a stable and competitive democracy.

Examples

- United States – Republican Party and Democratic Party.
- Ghana – New Patriotic Party (NPP) and National Democratic Congress (NDC).
- United Kingdom (historically) – Conservative and Labour Parties.

Merits

- Encourages political stability.
- Provides a clear choice for voters.
- Strong opposition ensures checks and balances.
- Reduces election confusion and vote splitting.

Demerits

- Limits political diversity and new ideas.
- Smaller parties are marginalised.

- May lead to polarisation and party rivalry.
- Citizens may feel their choices are too restricted.

D. Multi-Party System

A political system in which **more than two parties exist and actively compete** for power. This system offers the widest range of choices to voters.

Features

- Several political parties are registered and operate freely.
- Elections may lead to coalition governments if no party wins outright majority.
- Reflects diverse interests and ideologies.
- Encourages political participation.

Examples

- Nigeria – APC, PDP, LP, NNPP, and others.
- India – Indian National Congress, BJP, and many regional parties.
- Germany – CDU/CSU, SPD, Greens, FDP, etc.

Merits

- Promotes broad representation of diverse groups.
- Encourages participation and political education.
- Provides alternatives for voters.
- Reduces dominance by a single party.

Demerits

- May lead to unstable coalition governments.
- Slower decision-making due to compromise.
- Ethnic or sectional parties may promote division.
- Increases cost of governance and elections.

Nigeria's Experience with Party Systems

- **First Republic (1960–1966):** Multi-party system (NPC, NCNC, AG).
- **Second Republic (1979–1983):** Multi-party system (NPN, UPN, NPP, PRP, GNPP).
- **Third Republic (1992–1993):** Two-party system (SDP and NRC imposed by military government).
- **Fourth Republic (1999–Present):** Multi-party system (currently over 18 registered parties, with APC and PDP as dominant ones).

Though Nigeria operates a multi-party system, it is largely dominated by two main parties, creating a **de facto two-party** arrangement.

Factors Influencing a Country's Party System

Several factors determine the kind of party system a country operates:

1. Historical Development

A country's colonial past, wars, or revolutions shape its political structure. For example, former British colonies often adopt multi-party systems, while revolutionary states may support one-party dominance.

2. Constitutional Provisions and Electoral Laws

The constitution and electoral rules determine how many parties can operate. Systems like proportional representation encourage multiple parties, while first-past-the-post often leads to two-party systems.

3. Level of Political Awareness and Education

Informed and educated citizens support diverse political views, encouraging healthy party competition. Low awareness may limit participation to dominant or ethnic-based parties.

4. Ethnic, Religious, and Cultural Diversity

Diverse societies often produce many parties to represent different groups. However, to maintain national unity, rules may require parties to have broad, national appeal.

5. Media Freedom and Democratic Space

In democratic societies with free media, multiple parties can flourish. In authoritarian states, media control limits opposition and encourages one-party rule.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2021, Q4:** Define party system and explain any three types with examples.
- **NECO 2020, Q5:** Discuss the merits and demerits of a multi-party system.
- **WAEC 2019, Q3:** Explain Nigeria's experience with the two-party and multi-party systems.
- *"Discuss the advantages and disadvantages of the multi-party system in Nigeria and suggest ways to improve political representation."*
- Compare the two-party and multi-party systems using relevant examples.
- **NECO 2020, Q4:** Identify two advantages and two disadvantages each of the one-party and multi-party systems.
- **WAEC 2019, Q3:** Discuss Nigeria's experience with multi-party politics.

SS1 GOVERNMENT LESSON NOTES

THIRD TERM

1. Pressure Groups
2. Public Administration
3. Civil Service
4. Local Government
5. MIDTERM EXAMINATION
6. Pre-Colonial Administration in Nigeria
7. MIDTERM BREAK
8. Colonial Administration in Nigeria
9. Nationalism in Nigeria



WEEK ONE: PRESSURE GROUPS

A **pressure group** is an organised group of individuals who share common interests and work together to influence government policies and decisions without directly seeking political power. Unlike political parties, pressure groups do not contest elections to form government; rather, they seek to promote or defend specific causes, interests, or policies.

These groups function as intermediaries between the government and the people, representing the views of different segments of society such as workers, students, farmers, business people, religious groups, or professionals.

Types of Pressure Groups

Pressure groups can be classified based on their nature, goals, and membership. The main types include:

a. Economic/Occupational Pressure Groups

These represent the economic interests of members in specific professions or industries.

Examples: Nigeria Labour Congress (NLC), Manufacturers Association of Nigeria (MAN), Academic Staff Union of Universities (ASUU).

b. Professional Groups

These consist of individuals in the same profession who seek to promote the welfare and standards of their occupation.

Examples: Nigerian Bar Association (NBA), Nigerian Medical Association (NMA), Nigerian Union of Journalists (NUJ).

c. Religious Pressure Groups

These are organised around religious beliefs and aim to influence public policies in line with their doctrines.

Examples: Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN), Supreme Council for Islamic Affairs (SCIA).

d. Promotional/Cause Groups

These aim to promote specific issues or social causes such as human rights, the environment, or anti-corruption.

Examples: Civil Liberties Organisation (CLO), Environmental Rights Action (ERA), Women in Nigeria (WIN).

e. Ethnic or Cultural Groups

Formed to protect and promote the interests of particular ethnic groups.

Examples: Ohanaeze Ndigbo, Afenifere, Arewa Consultative Forum (ACF), Ijaw Youth Council (IYC).

f. Student and Youth Groups

Focused on protecting students' rights and youth interests.

Examples: National Association of Nigerian Students (NANS), Youth Council of Nigeria.

g. Institutional Groups

These include groups that are part of a formal government or quasi-government body, such as the military or civil service associations. Though not overtly political, they may influence decisions behind the scenes.

Functions of Pressure Groups

Pressure groups play crucial roles in a democracy and governance system. Their key functions include:

a. Representation

They serve as a voice for various segments of society, particularly minority or underrepresented groups.

b. Political Education

Pressure groups help to raise awareness about national issues and educate the public on government policies.

c. Policy Influence

They influence legislation and public policy by lobbying government officials and lawmakers.

d. Watchdog Function

Pressure groups hold governments accountable by monitoring actions and exposing corruption or abuse of power.

e. Promoting Accountability

By constantly engaging the government, pressure groups ensure that leaders act in the public interest.

f. Participation and Mobilisation

They encourage citizens to get involved in governance through protests, petitions, campaigns, and advocacy.

g. Conflict Resolution

Many pressure groups act as mediators between the government and the public in times of unrest or crisis (e.g., labour unions negotiating with government).

Methods of Operation (Tactics of Pressure Groups)

a. Lobbying:

Pressure groups meet with lawmakers and government officials to convince them to support or oppose certain policies.

b. Petitions and Letters:

They write formal appeals or complaints to authorities, expressing public concerns or demands.

c. Public Campaigns and Advocacy:

They use media, rallies, and public events to raise awareness and influence opinions on key issues.

d. Demonstrations and Protests:

Peaceful marches or gatherings are organised to express dissatisfaction and press for change.

e. Use of the Media:

They engage with newspapers, radio, TV, and social media to spread their message and gain support.

f. Legal Action:

They take legal steps, such as filing lawsuits, to challenge government decisions or defend rights.

g. Strikes and Boycotts:

Labour groups may stop work or refuse services to compel government attention or negotiation.

Differences Between Pressure Groups and Political Parties

Feature	Pressure Groups	Political Parties
Objective	Influence policy	Gain political power
Participation in Elections	Do not contest elections	Contest and sponsor candidates
Membership	Based on common interests	Open to all interested citizens
Scope	Focused on specific issues	Address broad national issues
Role	Act as watchdogs	Form and run government if elected

Importance of Pressure Groups in a Democracy

Strengthen public participation in governance: They encourage citizens to engage actively in political and policy matters.

Promote accountability and transparency: By monitoring government actions, they help expose corruption and demand responsible leadership.

Give voice to minority and marginalised groups: They represent the interests of groups that may be overlooked in mainstream politics.

Serve as watchdogs over government conduct: They check government excesses and advocate for the protection of rights.

Complement political parties by focusing on specific issues: Unlike parties, they concentrate on particular causes, helping to refine public policy.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2022, Q4:** Define a pressure group and explain any three methods it uses to influence government.
- **NECO 2021, Q5:** Differentiate between political parties and pressure groups.
- **WAEC 2019, Q3:** Explain four types of pressure groups with examples.
- *Evaluate the role of pressure groups in promoting good governance and democratic accountability in Nigeria.*

WEEK TWO: PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

Meaning of Public Administration

Public Administration refers to the system or process through which government policies, programmes, and decisions are formulated, implemented, and managed. It includes the organisation, management, and supervision of public services and affairs by government institutions and civil servants.

It involves all activities carried out by government officials and agencies to ensure that laws and policies are translated into action for the benefit of the public. Public administration is therefore the engine room of governance; it makes governance functional and service delivery possible.

It includes both the civil service and public service at various levels – federal, state, and local government – and ensures continuity in governance irrespective of political changes.

Features of Public Administration

The following are key characteristics or features of public administration:

a. Government-Oriented: Public administration is fundamentally a government activity. It operates within the framework of the state and is designed to serve the collective interest of the public, not to generate profits like private enterprises. Government institutions, such as ministries and parastatals, are established and funded to carry out these administrative functions. For example, the Ministry of Health exists to provide healthcare services, not to make money.

b. Bureaucratic in Structure: Public administration is organised in a systematic and formal structure, often referred to as a bureaucracy. This means it has defined levels of authority (a hierarchy), written rules and procedures, division of labour, and impersonality in operations. Each worker knows their position and duties, and decisions are made following set procedures rather than personal preferences. This ensures order, predictability, and consistency in governance.

c. Rule-Guided and Law-Abiding: All activities of public administration are carried out in strict compliance with the law. Public officials are not allowed to act arbitrarily; they must operate within legal and constitutional boundaries. For instance, civil servants must follow due process when recruiting staff or spending public funds. This rule-based nature helps prevent corruption and abuse of office.

d. Continuous in Nature: Public administration ensures continuity in government operations regardless of political changes. While politicians come and go through elections, public servants remain in office and carry out day-to-day governance. This continuity is essential for stability and long-term planning. For example, the permanent secretary in a ministry may serve under several different ministers but maintains the implementation of core policies.

e. Impersonal and Neutral: Public administrators are expected to perform their duties without favouritism, bias, or political allegiance. Whether the ruling party changes or not, they are required to serve all citizens equally and obey only the laws and professional ethics guiding their office. This neutrality preserves the integrity and trustworthiness of the public service.

f. Hierarchical and Specialised: Public administration is built on a clear chain of command, where authority flows from top management to subordinate officers. Each level in this structure has defined roles and responsibilities. Furthermore, tasks are assigned based on specialisation, meaning individuals and departments focus on areas in which they are trained or competent (e.g., Finance, Agriculture, Education).

g. Service-Oriented: The core goal of public administration is to deliver quality services to the citizens. These services may include education, healthcare, clean water, transportation, housing, and environmental protection. Unlike the private sector which seeks to maximise profits, public administration focuses on the welfare and development of the people.

h. Accountability and Transparency: Public administrators must justify their actions and decisions to the government and the public. They are responsible for the way public resources are managed and services are delivered. Transparency is achieved through audits, reports, oversight by bodies like the National Assembly, and freedom of information laws. This feature helps build public trust and discourages misuse of power or funds.

Functions of Public Administration

Public administration performs several essential functions that enable the state to function effectively. These include:

a. Policy Implementation: Public administration serves as the machinery that translates policies and laws into action. Once elected officials (legislature and executive) make decisions, it is the role of public administrators—ministries, departments, and agencies—to ensure those decisions are practically executed.

Example: If the National Assembly passes a law mandating free basic education, the Ministry of Education oversees the recruitment of teachers, construction of classrooms, distribution of learning materials, and monitoring of school enrolment across the country.

b. Provision of Public Services: Public administration ensures the government fulfills its responsibility of serving the public with essential services, such as good roads, potable water, power supply, healthcare, waste management, and security. These services are delivered through various MDAs (e.g., Ministry of Works, Ministry of Health). The goal is to improve the quality of life of citizens.

c. Revenue Collection and Budget Execution: A well-functioning public administration facilitates efficient revenue generation (e.g., taxes, fees, levies) and ensures funds are disbursed according to the national budget. Agencies like FIRS, Customs, and State Revenue Boards collect income, while Ministries of Finance at federal and state levels manage budget execution and ensure that expenditures are in line with legal appropriation.

d. Record Keeping and Documentation: Public administrators are responsible for maintaining official records and data required for effective decision-making. These include population censuses, birth and death certificates, land registries, employment records, and government archives. Proper documentation helps in policy planning, accountability, and continuity.

e. Advising Political Leaders: Top-level public administrators (like permanent secretaries and technocrats) advise politicians and elected officials based on data, technical expertise, and

institutional experience. Their input helps politicians craft realistic and workable policies, ensuring that decisions are not just politically popular but administratively feasible.

f. Regulation and Enforcement: Public administration helps maintain standards and quality control in various sectors by enforcing laws and regulations.

Examples:

- **NAFDAC** regulates the production and sale of drugs and food.
- **FCCPC** (Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission) protects consumers.

These agencies ensure compliance and protect public interest from harmful or exploitative practices.

g. Human Resource Management: Civil servants and public officers are recruited, trained, promoted, and disciplined through administrative mechanisms. The civil service commissions at all government levels ensure that public institutions have qualified, motivated, and well-managed personnel to deliver services effectively and ethically.

h. Promoting National Development: Through proper planning and execution of developmental programmes and projects (like roads, dams, rural electrification, and agricultural schemes), public administration plays a direct role in driving socio-economic development. It bridges the gap between government intentions and actual development on the ground.

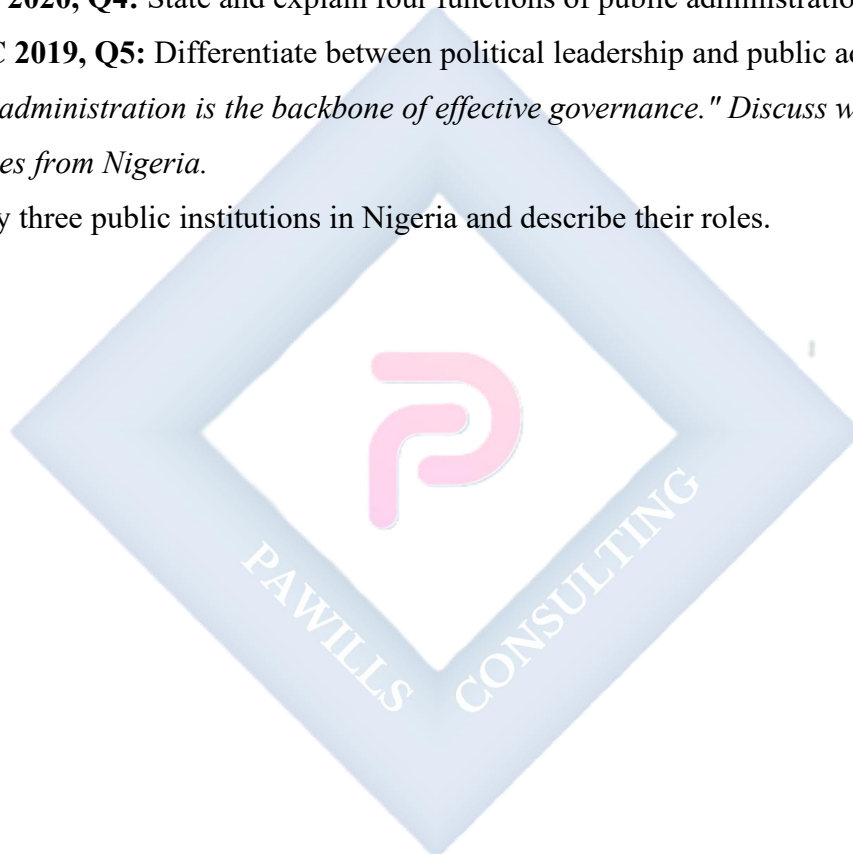
i. Conflict Resolution and Social Order: Agencies like the police, judiciary, and human rights commissions maintain law and order. They resolve disputes, investigate crimes, settle land disagreements, and ensure justice. This function is crucial for ensuring peaceful coexistence and public safety in society.

j. Emergency Management and Disaster Response: In times of crises—such as floods, disease outbreaks, fires, or terrorism—public administrative bodies like the National Emergency Management Agency (NEMA) coordinate quick responses. They mobilise relief materials, provide shelters, rescue victims, and work with other agencies to minimise loss of life and property.

EVALUATION

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2021, Q6:** Explain the term public administration and discuss any four of its features.
- **NECO 2020, Q4:** State and explain four functions of public administration.
- **WAEC 2019, Q5:** Differentiate between political leadership and public administration.
- *Public administration is the backbone of effective governance." Discuss with relevant examples from Nigeria.*
- List any three public institutions in Nigeria and describe their roles.



WEEK THREE: CIVIL SERVICE

The civil service refers to the body of permanent officials employed in government ministries, departments, and agencies who are responsible for the implementation of government policies and day-to-day administration of public affairs. These officials are career bureaucrats and remain in service regardless of changes in political leadership.

The civil service is part of the wider public service, but while public service includes institutions like the police, armed forces, teachers, and judiciary, the civil service is limited to employees in government ministries and departments directly involved in policy execution and administrative duties.

Structure of the Civil Service

The Nigerian civil service is structured in a hierarchical and departmental form, ensuring that responsibilities are clearly divided for effective performance. The structure can be described in the following layers:

a. Ministries and Departments

Each ministry is headed politically by a minister or commissioner (at the federal or state level), and administratively by a Permanent Secretary. The ministry is subdivided into departments and units based on specific functions.

b. Administrative Cadre

This is the core engine of the civil service. Officers in this group are responsible for drafting policies, interpreting them, and ensuring their implementation. Ranks include Permanent Secretaries, Directors, and various officers. They coordinate activities across departments and offer leadership in ministries.

c. Professional and Technical Cadre

These are specialists like doctors, engineers, lawyers, and economists who offer expert advice and services. Their role is to ensure that technical matters are handled with professional **competence** in line with government policies.

d. Clerical and Secretarial Cadre

This cadre handles the routine office duties such as filing, typing, documentation, and maintaining correspondence. They support the administrative processes by keeping records accurate and organised.

e. Junior Cadre (Support Staff)

These are the non-professional workers who provide essential services like cleaning, driving, dispatching files, and security. Though not involved in policymaking, they help ensure the smooth daily operation of offices.

Functions of the Civil Service

The civil service plays a crucial role in the administration of the state. Its major functions include:

a. Policy Implementation

This is one of the **primary duties** of the civil service. Once the government (executive and legislature) makes decisions and passes laws or policies, it is the responsibility of the civil service to **carry them out practically and effectively**. This includes drawing up implementation plans, allocating resources, supervising programmes, and ensuring that the intended goals are achieved.

Example: If a government introduces a free school feeding programme, it is the civil service—particularly the Ministry of Education and Ministry of Agriculture—that organises food procurement, delivery, monitoring, and reporting.

b. Policy Advice

Civil servants, particularly those in the **administrative and professional cadre**, are often called upon to provide **objective, research-based, and technical advice** to ministers, commissioners, and political leaders. Because civil servants are career professionals who remain in office regardless of which political party is in power, they offer **institutional memory** and continuity. Their advice helps to assess the **feasibility, cost, and potential impact** of proposed policies.

Example: Before introducing a new health insurance scheme, the Ministry of Health's permanent secretary and technical staff will advise the minister on logistics, budgeting, and target groups.

c. Record Keeping and Documentation

The civil service is in charge of **organising and maintaining official records and documents**. This includes statistics, reports, files, registers, and correspondence. These records are vital for **planning, decision-making, auditing, legal purposes**, and historical reference. Proper documentation also supports transparency and accountability.

Example: Ministries of Interior and National Population Commission handle birth and death records, which are essential for national planning.

d. Financial Management

Civil servants are deeply involved in the **preparation, execution, and monitoring of government budgets**. This includes forecasting revenue, collecting taxes or fees, allocating funds, making government purchases, and ensuring that all expenditures are made according to financial regulations.

Example: The Ministry of Finance and Budget Office work with other ministries to prepare annual budgets and track how funds are used.

e. Public Service Delivery

One of the most visible roles of the civil service is to deliver essential services to citizens. This covers a wide range of sectors such as healthcare, education, electricity, water supply, waste management, and transport. The civil service ensures that these services reach all parts of the

country fairly and effectively.

Example: The Ministry of Works oversees the construction and maintenance of federal roads and bridges.

f. Continuity of Government

Unlike political officeholders who may leave office after elections, civil servants are permanent staff. They remain in their positions and ensure that government activities continue smoothly and without interruption. This guarantees stability, order, and effective service delivery, even during times of political transition or change of government.

Example: When a new president or governor is elected, the civil servants in each ministry remain to brief and support the new administration.

g. Regulation and Supervision

Civil servants help enforce rules and regulations passed by the government. They supervise contractors, monitor projects, regulate trade, ensure safety standards, and enforce laws across various sectors. This ensures that government policies are followed, public money is not misused, and projects are delivered to standard.

Example: NAFDAC (National Agency for Food and Drug Administration and Control) ensures that only safe and approved drugs and food items are sold in Nigeria.

h. Human Resource Management

The civil service is responsible for recruiting, training, promoting, and disciplining public servants. Through agencies such as the Civil Service Commission and training institutions like ASCON, civil servants are developed and managed to ensure an efficient and capable workforce.

Example: The Civil Service Commission oversees fair and merit-based appointments and promotions within ministries.

i. Monitoring and Evaluation

Civil servants monitor government policies, projects, and programmes to **track performance and measure impact**. They also evaluate completed projects to see if they met their goals and

suggest areas for improvement.

Example: A Department of Planning or Monitoring and Evaluation in each ministry often reviews the performance of contractors or assesses the effectiveness of social schemes.

j. Enforcement of Government Policies

Beyond implementation, the civil service also ensures that government policies are **respected and enforced** across the nation. For example, agencies such as the Federal Road Safety Corps (FRSC) enforce traffic regulations, and Environmental Protection Agencies enforce environmental laws.

Control of the Civil Service

Controlling the civil service is necessary to ensure **efficiency, discipline, transparency, and accountability**. The following mechanisms help regulate the civil service:

a. Civil Service Commission

This body is responsible for **recruitment, promotion, discipline, and retirement** of civil servants. At the federal level, this role is carried out by the **Federal Civil Service Commission (FCSC)**.

b. Code of Conduct Bureau and Tribunal

Civil servants are subject to the **Code of Conduct** which governs ethical behaviour, asset declaration, and avoidance of conflict of interest.

c. Ministerial Oversight

Ministers or commissioners supervise the ministries politically, ensuring that civil servants align with the government's policy direction.

d. Legislative Oversight

The National and State Assemblies monitor the activities of ministries and agencies through **committee hearings, budget reviews, and audits.**

e. Auditors and Financial Regulators

The **Auditor-General's Office** and **Budget Office** control civil service finances to ensure compliance with budgetary guidelines.

f. Reforms and Training

Periodic reforms aim to restructure and improve civil service performance. Institutions like the **Administrative Staff College of Nigeria (ASCON)** and the **Public Service Institute** provide training and retraining.

g. Judicial Review

Civil servants can be held accountable in courts of law for misconduct or abuse of office, ensuring respect for the rule of law.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2018, Q4:** Highlight four functions of the civil service.
- **NECO 2021, Q5:** Explain the term 'civil service' and outline its organisational structure.
- **WAEC 2020, Q3:** State and explain four ways of controlling the civil service in Nigeria.

WEEK FOUR: LOCAL GOVERNMENT

Local Government

Local government refers to the third tier of government, established by law to administer the affairs of people at the grassroots level. It operates within a defined geographical area and is governed by elected representatives. The primary aim of local government is to bring governance closer to the people and to address local needs more promptly and efficiently than state or federal governments can.

According to the 1999 Constitution of Nigeria (Section 7), the local government is guaranteed and recognised as a distinct and essential part of the federal structure. There are 774 Local Government Areas (LGAs) in Nigeria, each responsible for local administration and service delivery within its jurisdiction. Local governments help decentralise power, promote participatory governance, and drive rural development.

Structure of Local Government in Nigeria

The structure of the local government system in Nigeria is both **political and administrative**, comprising elected political officials and career civil servants working together.

a. The Chairman

The Local Government Chairman is the **chief executive officer** of the council. Elected by the people, the chairman oversees the implementation of council decisions, supervises departments, and manages day-to-day administration. The chairman plays a role similar to that of a governor or president, but at the local level.

b. The Vice Chairman

The Vice Chairman is also elected and serves as the **deputy to the chairman**. He or she supports the chairman and may act in their absence.

c. The Councillors

Each Local Government Area is divided into **wards**, and each ward elects a councillor. Collectively, councillors form the **legislative arm** of the local government, which is responsible for:

- Making bye-laws
- Approving budgets
- Overseeing executive actions

This body functions like a mini-parliament at the local level.

d. Secretary to the Local Government

Appointed by the chairman, the secretary acts as the **coordinator of all departments** and serves as a liaison between political officeholders and the civil service.

e. Supervisory Councillors

These officials are appointed by the chairman and are placed in charge of various departments such as:

- Health
- Education
- Works
- Agriculture

They supervise the execution of projects and ensure departmental performance.

f. Heads of Departments (HODs)

These are **career civil servants** who manage the daily operations of each department. They are responsible for technical input, staff supervision, and project implementation.

g. Departments

Common departments in a local government include:

- Works and Housing

- Health
- Agriculture
- Education
- Finance
- Social Development and Youth Affairs

Function of Local Government

The **Local Government** serves as the **closest level of government to the people**, especially those in rural or semi-urban areas. It plays a critical role in grassroots development and ensuring that public services are delivered efficiently. The Fourth Schedule of the 1999 Constitution of Nigeria outlines its statutory responsibilities.

a. Provision of Basic Social Services

Local governments are primarily responsible for **delivering essential services** that improve the quality of life at the grassroots level. These include:

- **Construction and maintenance of primary schools:** They ensure that children within their communities have access to basic education by building classrooms, paying teachers' salaries (in some cases), and maintaining facilities.
- **Establishment and upkeep of primary healthcare centres:** Local governments provide **basic health services**, including maternal care, immunisation, treatment of minor illnesses, and health education.
- **Construction and repair of feeder roads and bridges:** These infrastructures link rural areas to towns and markets, promoting **economic activity and mobility**.
- **Building and maintenance of public markets and parks:** These spaces serve both **commercial and social purposes**, fostering local economic growth and community interaction.

Such services **promote development**, improve health and education outcomes, and support the welfare of rural dwellers.

b. Registration and Records

Local governments are charged with maintaining accurate records of **births, deaths, and marriages** in their jurisdiction. This function is fundamental for:

- **National planning and budgeting:** Accurate population data helps both federal and state governments plan effectively for resources like schools, hospitals, and infrastructure.
- **Legal identification:** Proper documentation ensures citizens have **official identity and legal status**, which is necessary for accessing services like education, voting, or inheritance claims.
- **Vital statistics:** These records also contribute to data used in public health and demographic research.

c. Revenue Generation

Although local governments receive statutory allocations from the federation account, they are also empowered to raise revenue internally through:

- **Market stall fees and business permits:** Traders pay daily or weekly fees for using public markets.
- **Motor park dues:** Commercial transport operators pay levies to use parks and terminals maintained by the council.
- **Radio and television licences:** Residents may be required to pay symbolic licences for owning these devices.
- **Tenement rates:** This is a form of property tax paid by landlords or tenants based on the value of their buildings.

Internally generated revenue (IGR) is vital for funding **local development projects, maintenance of infrastructure**, and running the day-to-day operations of the council.

d. Waste Management and Environmental Sanitation

Cleanliness and hygiene are vital for public health. Local governments are tasked with:

- **Collecting domestic and commercial refuse:** This includes house-to-house waste collection or managing community dumping sites.
- **Maintaining drains and culverts:** Especially during the rainy season, this prevents flooding and the spread of disease.
- **Running public awareness campaigns:** Citizens are educated on hygiene practices and environmental safety.
- **Inspecting food vendors and sanitation conditions in markets and abattoirs:** This prevents food contamination and the spread of communicable diseases.

This function reduces the occurrence of illnesses such as cholera, typhoid, and malaria, which are common in poorly managed environments.

e. Local Economic Development

The local government is in a position to **stimulate economic growth** by promoting:

- **Smallholder farming:** They assist farmers with seedlings, fertilisers, and access to markets.
- **Support for artisans and micro-enterprises:** Councils may offer **training programmes**, equipment leasing, and workspace development.
- **Cottage industries:** These are small-scale, home-based production activities such as soap making, weaving, or pottery. Councils encourage such industries by providing startup grants or markets for finished products.
- **Vocational centres:** Some local governments run skills acquisition centres for the unemployed, especially the youth and women.

These efforts help **reduce poverty, promote self-reliance, and increase employment** at the community level.

f. Peace and Security

Although local governments do not control police forces, they still play a **supportive role in maintaining law and order**, including:

- **Community policing:** Collaborating with neighbourhood watch groups, traditional rulers, and the police to monitor criminal activities.
- **Conflict resolution:** Councils help mediate disputes over land, marriage, chieftaincy, or communal issues before they escalate.
- **Establishing vigilante or local security outfits** (in compliance with law): These assist in patrolling and intelligence gathering.

Their proximity to the people allows local governments to respond quickly to security concerns before they grow into crises.

g. Regulation of Markets and Motor Parks

The local government regulates the day-to-day operations of **public trading spaces and transportation hubs**:

- **Market organisation:** Ensuring traders are allocated stalls, and market days are properly scheduled.
- **Hygiene enforcement:** Inspectors ensure that goods, especially food, meet health standards and that the environment is clean.
- **Motor park management:** They collect parking dues, ensure proper queuing of vehicles, and maintain order among transport unions.
- **Price regulation (in some cases):** Councils may work with market leaders to control the prices of certain staple goods and prevent hoarding.

Such regulation enhances safety, hygiene, and economic coordination in densely populated areas.

h. Implementation of State and Federal Policies

Local governments serve as **implementation arms** of higher levels of government. They carry out nationwide programmes such as:

- **Immunisation campaigns:** Health officials from local councils coordinate vaccine distribution and administration.
- **Voter registration and election mobilisation:** They help the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) organise and sensitise communities.
- **Census and national surveys:** They assist the National Population Commission in enumerating residents.
- **Educational campaigns:** For instance, councils promote enrolment in the Universal Basic Education (UBE) programme.

Their involvement ensures that national policies **reach the grassroots efficiently** and meet the specific needs of local communities.

Problems Facing Local Governments in Nigeria

Despite their importance, local governments in Nigeria face numerous challenges that hinder their effectiveness.

a. Financial Mismanagement

Widespread corruption, embezzlement, and poor accounting practices prevent funds from being used for public benefit. Budgets are often inflated and misused.

b. Overdependence on State Governments

State governors often control local government funds through **Joint Allocation Accounts**, which limit the autonomy of local councils and their ability to plan and execute projects independently.

c. Inadequate Funding

The share of national revenue allocated to local governments is usually insufficient. Many local councils also have **weak capacity** to generate internal revenue.

d. Lack of Skilled Personnel

Most local governments are staffed by **underqualified or poorly trained workers**, which affects policy implementation and service delivery.

e. Political Interference

Local government elections are often manipulated by ruling parties at the state level. Appointments may be based on political loyalty rather than merit, resulting in poor leadership.

f. Irregular Elections

In many cases, elected local government officials are replaced by **caretaker committees**, undermining democracy and accountability at the local level.

g. Weak Audit and Oversight Systems

There is limited monitoring of local government spending. Without proper auditing, mismanagement goes undetected and unpunished.

Reforms of Local Government in Nigeria

Reforming local governments is necessary to enhance their performance, credibility, and ability to deliver services effectively.

a. Financial Autonomy

Local governments should be allowed to **control their own finances** and receive direct allocation from the federation account without state interference.

b. Transparent Elections

Local government elections should be handled by an **independent electoral body**, not the State Independent Electoral Commission (SIEC), to ensure fairness and credibility.

c. Anti-Corruption Measures

Strengthening internal audit systems and involving anti-corruption agencies like **EFCC and ICPC** in monitoring local government finances can reduce fraud.

d. Capacity Building

Regular **training and retraining** of local government staff will improve professionalism and administrative capacity.

e. Improved Revenue Generation

Expanding local tax bases and adopting **modern revenue collection methods** (e.g., digital platforms) can help councils increase their income.

f. Community Participation

Involving community members in budgeting and decision-making will ensure that local governments are responsive to the people's needs.

g. Clearer Constitutional Role

Amending the constitution to give **greater clarity and protection** to the functions and independence of local governments would improve their status and operations.

PAST WAEC/NECO QUESTIONS

- **WAEC 2019 Q3:** Explain the functions of local government in Nigeria.
- **NECO 2020 Q4:** Identify and explain four problems facing local government administration in Nigeria.
- **WAEC 2021 Q5:** Suggest four ways the performance of local governments can be improved.

WEEK SIX: PRE-COLONIAL ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA

ORIGIN OF THE HAUSA/FULANI POLITICAL SYSTEM

A. The Hausa Kingdoms

The Hausa Bakwai, meaning the “Seven True Hausa States,” were a group of culturally and politically connected city-states that formed the core of Hausa civilisation in pre-colonial northern Nigeria. These states—Daura, Katsina, Zaria (Zazzau), Kano, Gobir, Rano, and Biram—shared a common ancestry, language, religion (Islam), and administrative traditions, yet each maintained its own independence and distinct historical development.

According to Hausa oral traditions and legends, the Hausa Bakwai were founded by the children of Bayajidda, a legendary figure said to have migrated from Baghdad and married the Queen of Daura. The seven states were ruled by the sons and grandsons of Bayajidda, who established their own kingdoms. Because of this shared origin, the Hausa Bakwai are often referred to as the “legitimate Hausa states,” as opposed to the Banza Bakwai (illegitimate seven), which developed later and included neighbouring ethnic groups influenced by Hausa culture.

B. The Fulani Jihad

The **Fulani Jihad** of 1804 stands as a major historical event that reshaped the political, religious, and social landscape of Northern Nigeria. Led by Usman dan Fodio, a respected Fulani Islamic scholar, teacher, and reformer, the Jihad was primarily a religious movement aimed at purifying Islam and reforming the corrupt and oppressive leadership of many Hausa kingdoms. The movement resulted in the overthrow of several Hausa rulers and the establishment of one of the largest Islamic empires in sub-Saharan Africa; the Sokoto Caliphate.

By the late 18th century, Islam had spread across many Hausa city-states, but it had become deeply corrupted and mixed with traditional pagan practices. Many Hausa rulers, while professing Islam, engaged in immorality, heavy taxation, oppression, and neglect of Sharia law. The poor and the devout Muslim population suffered under these conditions.

Usman dan Fodio, born in 1754 in **Gobir**, was a member of the Fulani ethnic group and a strong advocate of **orthodox Islam**. As a teacher and preacher, he gathered a large following and began to **criticise the excesses of the Hausa rulers**, especially the King (Sarki) of Gobir. He demanded justice, religious reforms, and the protection of the Muslim community.

When the ruler of Gobir, Sarkin Nafata, and later Yunfa (a former student of Usman dan Fodio), began to feel threatened by his growing influence, they attempted to suppress him. This persecution led to armed conflict, marking the beginning of the *Jihad (Holy War)* in 1804.

With support from many Fulani herdsmen, Hausa peasants, and disaffected Muslim clerics, Usman dan Fodio declared Jihad against the oppressive Hausa rulers. The Jihad spread rapidly across the region due to its religious appeal and the people's dissatisfaction with the existing leadership.

Key features of the Jihad included:

- **Military campaigns** against Hausa kingdoms such as Kano, Katsina, Zaria, Gobir, and others.
- Overthrow of corrupt rulers and replacement with **Emirs** loyal to the Caliphate and committed to Islamic principles.
- Establishment of new Islamic institutions, schools, and courts based on *Sharia law*.

By 1810, the Jihad had succeeded in toppling most of the Hausa states. Usman dan Fodio, however, chose not to rule directly. Instead, he created a centralised Islamic empire known as the **Sokoto Caliphate**, with his son **Muhammadu Bello** as the ruler in **Sokoto** and his brother **Abdullahi dan Fodio** as the leader of the western region, headquartered in **Gwandu**.

The **Sokoto Caliphate** became the largest and most powerful empire in West Africa during the 19th century. It was a **theocratic state**, where religious leaders doubled as political administrators. The caliphate was divided into **emirates**, each governed by an Emir who reported to the Sultan in Sokoto. Islamic law (Sharia) guided governance, education, and justice.

C. The Sokoto Caliphate

The Sokoto Caliphate, established in the early 19th century following the successful Fulani Jihad led by Usman dan Fodio, became the largest, most organised, and most influential Islamic state in West Africa. It significantly altered the religious, political, and social dynamics of the region, replacing the previous corrupt and fragmented Hausa systems with a centralised Islamic theocracy grounded in Sharia law.

After the Jihad, Usman dan Fodio did not crown himself king in the traditional sense. Instead, he assumed the title of Caliph (Amir al-Mu'minin), meaning Commander of the Faithful, to reflect the religious nature of his leadership. He founded a state based on Islamic principles of governance, justice, scholarship, and morality.

The Caliphate expanded rapidly, both politically and territorially. By mid-19th century, it spanned across most of modern-day northern Nigeria, as well as parts of Niger, Cameroon, and Benin Republic.

The Sokoto Caliphate was highly decentralised but unified under Islamic ideology. It had the following structure:

1. **The Sultan (Caliph)** – Based in Sokoto, the Sultan was both the spiritual and political leader of the Caliphate. He oversaw general policies and provided religious and moral guidance. Usman dan Fodio was succeeded by his son, Muhammadu Bello.
2. **The Emirate System** – The Caliphate was divided into emirates, each governed by an Emir. These emirs were usually appointed for their religious knowledge, loyalty, and leadership skills. Though autonomous in local matters, they owed allegiance to the Sultan and implemented Islamic laws.
3. **Gwandu Administration** – Usman's brother, Abdullahi dan Fodio, administered the western part of the Caliphate from Gwandu. This division ensured better management of the vast empire.

STRUCTURE OF THE HAUSA/FULANI POLITICAL SYSTEM

The political system was **highly centralised, hierarchical, and theocratic**. Authority flowed from the top (the Caliph) down to the lowest level (village heads).

A. The Sultan (Caliph)

At the apex of the Hausa/Fulani political system was the **Sultan**, also known as the **Caliph**, who resided in **Sokoto**. The Sultan was the **spiritual and political leader** of the entire **Sokoto Caliphate**, which was one of the largest empires in West Africa during the 19th century. His authority extended across all emirates that made up the caliphate.

The Sultan's primary responsibility was to **uphold and propagate Islam** across the territories. He ensured that Islamic doctrines and legal principles (Sharia) were implemented consistently. In addition to his religious duties, the Sultan acted as the **overarching political authority**, having the power to **appoint or depose Emirs**, particularly if they deviated from Islamic standards or governance expectations. His position was revered and symbolic of unity across the Fulani-controlled emirates.

B. The Emir

Beneath the Sultan in the political structure was the Emir, who governed an individual emirate, such as Kano, Zaria, Katsina, or Sokoto itself. The Emir was both spiritual and political leader of his emirate and functioned almost as a monarch within his domain, although his loyalty remained with the Sultan at Sokoto or Gwandu (depending on the region of the Caliphate).

The Emir was a powerful figure who combined the executive, legislative, and judicial functions of government. As spiritual leader, he was expected to lead by Islamic example, supervise mosques, and promote religious education. As military commander, he controlled a standing army and could lead campaigns or defend the emirate from internal and external threats. Administratively, the Emir oversaw taxation, land allocation, public works, and the general well-being of his subjects.

While his powers were extensive, he was expected to rule in consultation with a council of advisers and within the boundaries of Islamic jurisprudence. His leadership was also not entirely autocratic, as he could be removed by the Sultan in cases of misconduct or failure to govern according to Islamic principles.

C. The Council of Advisers

To assist the Emir in governing effectively, there was a Council of Advisers made up of top-ranking officials who headed various administrative and military functions. These advisers played essential roles in ensuring the emirate was run smoothly and in accordance with Islamic teachings and local customs. The council typically comprised the following:

- **Waziri:** The chief adviser or prime minister, he was often the most powerful figure next to the Emir. The Waziri coordinated other officials, implemented policies, and managed state affairs. He could also act on behalf of the Emir when required.
- **Madaki:** The head of the army, responsible for recruitment, military training, and commanding the emirate's forces during warfare or defence operations.
- **Galadima:** Administrator of the **capital city** of the emirate. The Galadima ensured the maintenance of law and order and the smooth running of urban governance.
- **Sarkin Fada:** The **palace chief** who managed the daily affairs of the Emir's court. He regulated palace staff, organised official events, and conveyed royal messages.
- **Maaji:** The **treasurer or financial officer**, in charge of collecting taxes, managing revenue, and overseeing expenditures.
- **Alkali:** The **chief Islamic judge**, who interpreted and applied **Sharia law** in both civil and criminal matters. The Alkali's court was the highest court in the emirate.
- **Sarkin Ruwa:** The **officer in charge of water resources**, ensuring the maintenance of wells, streams, and irrigation systems vital for agriculture and public health.

This council ensured that the Emir's decisions were well-informed and that governance was inclusive, strategic, and grounded in Islamic values.

D. District Heads (Hakimai)

Each emirate was divided into several **districts**, with each district governed by a **Hakimi (plural: Hakimai)**. These district heads were usually members of the ruling class, loyal allies of the Emir, or respected Islamic scholars. Their primary roles included:

- Maintaining law and order within the district.

- Collecting taxes and other levies on behalf of the Emir.
- Supervising village and ward heads.
- Ensuring that the judicial system functioned properly at the district level.

Hakimai acted as intermediaries between the central emirate administration and the rural population, effectively decentralising governance and ensuring that even remote areas were under political and religious supervision.

E. Village Heads (Mai-Unguwa) and Ward Heads (Bulama)

At the lowest but equally crucial level of the Hausa/Fulani administrative hierarchy were the village heads (Mai-Unguwa) and ward heads (Bulama). These individuals were responsible for day-to-day administration at the grassroots level.

- The **Mai-Unguwa** oversaw an entire village. His duties included resolving minor disputes, ensuring the implementation of the Emir's laws, collecting minor levies, and maintaining community peace.
- The **Bulama** was in charge of a ward or family compound within the village. He ensured that residents fulfilled civic obligations such as tax payment, attending community meetings, and contributing to communal labour.

These local officials played a vital role in maintaining order, mobilising community efforts, and relaying information from the district heads to the grassroots. They were typically selected based on integrity, age, and loyalty to both the Emir and district heads.

FEATURES OF THE HAUSA/FULANI POLITICAL SYSTEM

1. Centralised Authority

One of the defining features of the Hausa/Fulani political system was its highly centralised structure of authority. At the helm was the Emir, who wielded absolute power over all aspects of governance in the emirate. However, the Emir was not autocratic in practice. He governed in consultation with a council of advisers, including the Waziri, Madaki, and other key officials. These advisers provided technical, religious, and administrative guidance. While the Emir held final authority, his leadership was legitimised by both religious adherence and administrative competence.

2. Theocratic System

The governance of the Hausa/Fulani emirates was deeply rooted in Islamic principles, making it a theocratic system. The Emir, along with his council and judiciary, derived authority from Sharia law, which served as the basis for legislation, justice, and public morality. This theocratic nature distinguished the system from others in pre-colonial Nigeria. Religious scholars (Ulamas) and judges (Alkalis) played central roles in policy interpretation and judicial rulings, ensuring that the day-to-day governance conformed to Islamic teachings.

3. Bureaucracy

The system had a well-developed bureaucratic structure. Governance was carried out through a network of appointed officials, each with clearly defined roles. From high-ranking advisers like the Waziri and Madaki, to local authorities such as the Hakimi (district heads), Mai-Unguwa (village heads), and Bulama (ward heads), there was a hierarchical chain of command that ensured the smooth flow of information and decisions from the centre to the grassroots. This bureaucratic arrangement enhanced efficiency, accountability, and control across the emirates.

4. Hereditary Succession

Leadership within the Hausa/Fulani system was largely hereditary, especially in the case of the Emirs and district heads. Succession was typically passed down through the ruling families. However, it was not strictly automatic. The endorsement of the religious elite and Islamic scholars was essential to validate a new ruler's legitimacy. This blend of hereditary privilege and religious sanction helped maintain both political continuity and moral credibility.

5. Efficient Taxation System

Another notable feature was the emirate's organised system of taxation, which served both civic and religious purposes. Different types of taxes included:

- **Zakat** – a compulsory alms-giving by Muslims, used for the welfare of the poor and religious causes.
- **Jizya** – a tax imposed on non-Muslims (dhimmis) in exchange for protection and exemption from military service.
- **Kharaj** – a land tax collected from agricultural produce.

These taxes provided the state with revenue to fund public services, administrative duties, and military campaigns, while reinforcing religious obligations.

6. Judicial System

The judicial arm of the Hausa/Fulani system was highly organised and guided by Islamic jurisprudence. The courts were presided over by Alkalis (Islamic judges) who applied Sharia law to adjudicate both civil and criminal matters. The Alkali courts were respected and accessible, making justice delivery both predictable and religiously legitimate. For more complex cases, appeals could be taken to higher courts within the emirate or referred to the Emir himself.

7. Standing Army

Security and territorial expansion were essential concerns of the emirates. The Hausa/Fulani system maintained a standing army, commanded by the Madaki (head of the military). The army was used not only to protect the emirate from external threats and internal rebellion but also to enforce law and order. Soldiers were drawn from loyal families and sometimes conscripted from local populations. The effectiveness of the military ensured peace and facilitated the spread of Islam and political control over new territories.

ROLES OF KEY OFFICIALS

Position	Function
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Emir	Supreme ruler, commander of the army, and religious head.
Waziri	Chief adviser; coordinated administrative matters.
Madaki	Military commander.
Galadima	Administrator of the capital city.
Alkali	Islamic judge who handled civil and criminal cases.
Hakimi	District governor responsible for tax collection and law enforcement.
Bulama / Mai-Unguwa	Local heads managing community affairs.

ADVANTAGES OF THE SYSTEM

- Strong and disciplined leadership.
- Efficient tax and revenue collection.
- Well-organised bureaucracy and military.
- Promotion of Islamic education and values.
- Stable government over vast territories.

LIMITATIONS OF THE SYSTEM

- Autocracy: Power was concentrated in a single ruler.
- Religious intolerance: Non-Muslims were heavily taxed or marginalised.
- Slavery: Enslavement of war captives was widespread.
- Exclusion of women and commoners from decision-making.

COMPARISON WITH MODERN ADMINISTRATION

Hausa/Fulani System	Modern Nigerian System
Emir is unelected	President is elected
Based on Sharia Law	Based on Constitution
Hereditary succession	Democratic elections
Religious governance	Secular governance
Centralised rule	Power is decentralised (federalism)

LEGACY OF THE SYSTEM

Many elements of the Hausa/Fulani system remain today:

- Traditional rulers (Emirs) still serve ceremonial and advisory roles.
- Sharia law is still applied in civil matters in many northern states.
- The Islamic education system continues to be influential.

WAEC/NECO PAST QUESTIONS

1. **WAEC June 2018** – *“Describe the structure of the Hausa/Fulani pre-colonial political system.”*
2. **NECO June 2020** – *“Outline five features of the Hausa/Fulani political system.”*
3. **WAEC June 2016** – *“List and explain four roles of the Emir in the Hausa/Fulani pre-colonial administration.”*
4. Identify five officials under the Emir and explain their roles.
5. Identify five officials under the Emir and explain their roles.

WEEK EIGHT: PRE-COLONIAL ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA II – YORUBA AND IGBO

Introduction

Before the advent of British colonial rule, Nigerian societies governed themselves according to their customs, traditions, and levels of political development. Two major examples of pre-colonial governance systems in Nigeria are the **centralised Yoruba system** and the **decentralised Igbo system**. These systems reflected the values, religious beliefs, and organisational structures of the respective communities.

The Yoruba Pre-Colonial Political System

1. Overview

The Yoruba people, one of the largest ethnic groups in Nigeria, primarily inhabit the south-western region of the country, including present-day Oyo, Ogun, Osun, Ondo, Ekiti, and Lagos States. Before colonial rule, the Yoruba developed a sophisticated and highly centralised political system, with the **Oyo Empire** serving as the most prominent and influential example.

The Oyo Empire, which reached its peak between the 17th and 18th centuries, was a powerful and well-structured state. Its administrative framework was monarchical—led by a king known as the **Alaafin of Oyo**, who served both political and spiritual roles. The empire was divided into provinces and vassal towns ruled by subordinate chiefs and local rulers (**Baales and Obas**) who paid tribute and allegiance to the **Alaafin**.

The Yoruba political system was marked by a clear hierarchy and institutional balance of power. Despite the king's prestige and authority, his powers were not absolute. The **Oyomesi**, a council of seven high-ranking chiefs, acted as kingmakers and advisers, while the **Ogboni** society, a religious and judicial body composed of revered elders, ensured justice and the protection of customs.

What made the Yoruba system particularly advanced was its combination of **central authority with decentralised governance**. While the Alaafin was supreme, individual towns retained

some autonomy under their own Obas and councils. Additionally, the **Aare Ona Kakanfo** served as the military commander, ensuring the kingdom's security and expansion, but was strategically based outside the capital to avoid direct interference in central governance.

Moreover, Yoruba towns were typically **urban and organised**, often built around palaces and market squares. These towns were centres of trade, administration, and culture. The political system was not only a means of governance but also reflected the **religious beliefs, cultural sophistication, and diplomatic traditions** of the Yoruba people.

Key Political Institutions

a. The Alaafin (King)

The Alaafin was the supreme ruler of the Oyo Empire and was regarded as the political and spiritual head of the kingdom. He was seen as a semi-divine figure and was greatly revered. However, his power was checked by other institutions.

b. The Oyomesi

This was a council of seven principal chiefs who served as **kingmakers and senior advisers**. They could compel the Alaafin to abdicate the throne if he ruled unjustly by sending him an empty calabash or parrot's eggs — a symbol of rejection.

c. The Ogboni Society

The Ogboni was a religious and judicial council made up of revered elders and priests. It acted as a check on both the Alaafin and the Oyomesi and helped maintain justice and religious order.

d. The Aare Ona Kakanfo

He was the commander of the military forces. Though a powerful figure, he was not allowed to live in the capital to prevent military dominance over civil authority.

e. Local Chiefs – Obas and Baales

Towns and villages under the Oyo Empire were ruled by Obas (kings) and Baales (lesser chiefs) who administered local affairs but paid tribute to the Alaafin.

Key Features of the Yoruba Political System

1. Monarchical and Centralised

The Yoruba political system, particularly in the Oyo Empire, was **monarchical**, with a king known as the **Alaafin** occupying the pinnacle of the political hierarchy. The Alaafin was both the spiritual and temporal head of the empire. He governed a vast territory that included both the metropolitan capital (Oyo-Ile) and numerous subordinate towns and provinces. Power was centralised in his hands, and he was recognised as the sovereign authority, though his power was subject to traditional institutions that served as checks on his rule. His centralised leadership allowed for unity, administrative efficiency, and coordinated expansion of the empire.

2. Checks and Balances

Despite the king's exalted status, the Oyo Empire had an effective system of checks and balances that prevented abuse of power. Chief among these was the Oyomesi, a council of seven powerful chiefs led by the Bashorun, who had the authority to remove a tyrannical Alaafin by symbolically sending him an empty calabash or parrot's egg. Another important body was the Ogboni society, a secretive but highly influential group of elders and priests responsible for maintaining justice, tradition, and spiritual order. Together, these institutions balanced the power of the monarchy and ensured accountability within the system.

3. Hereditary Succession

Leadership in the Yoruba system followed a pattern of hereditary succession, especially within the royal lineage. However, succession was not automatic. Prospective heirs were selected from eligible royal families and had to be vetted and approved by the Oyomesi. This blended approach of heredity and selection ensured continuity while allowing a measure of control to prevent unqualified individuals from ascending the throne. It also helped preserve stability and legitimacy in leadership succession.

4. Fusion of Religion and Politics

In the Yoruba political system, there was a strong integration of religious and political authority. The Alaafin was regarded as a semi-divine figure who ruled by divine right. His legitimacy derived not only from lineage and tradition but also from his religious standing. He performed spiritual rituals, served as a link between the gods and the people, and worked closely with the Ogboni, who were spiritual custodians of the land. This fusion reinforced loyalty to the king and added a sacred dimension to political authority.

5. Strong Military Institution

The Oyo Empire maintained a formidable standing army, which was crucial to its internal stability and external conquests. The military was led by the Aare Ona Kakanfo, the generalissimo of the empire, who operated independently from the capital to avoid interfering in civil matters. The army was used to suppress rebellions, defend the empire's borders, and expand territorial influence, particularly toward the south and west. The military strength of the Oyo Empire was a key reason for its dominance in the region and its ability to exact tribute from neighbouring states.

The Igbo Pre-Colonial Political System

Overview

The Igbo people, predominantly found in south-eastern Nigeria, developed a distinctly different political system from their Yoruba and Hausa/Fulani counterparts. While the Yoruba and Hausa/Fulani societies operated centralised monarchies, the Igbo embraced a decentralised, republican and participatory form of governance. This political culture reflected their strong emphasis on individual freedom, communal consensus, and egalitarianism.

Unlike other major ethnic groups, the Igbo did not have kings or a centralised authority in most areas. Instead, governance was organised at the village and clan level, where decisions were made collectively by elders, titled men, age grades, and other respected members of society. Each village functioned almost like a small independent republic, managing its affairs through inclusive deliberations and general consensus.

Power in the Igbo system resided in the village assembly, also known as the *Ama-ala*, which comprised all adult males of the community. These assemblies served as the highest decision-making body, with members discussing matters ranging from dispute resolution to communal projects and leadership selection. Everyone had a voice, reinforcing the democratic nature of Igbo governance.

In essence, the Igbo pre-colonial political system was acephalous, meaning "headless," yet it functioned with remarkable order and stability. It demonstrated how a society could thrive without kings or formal states, using communal dialogue, mutual respect, and collective leadership. This system fostered grassroots democracy, encouraged public participation, and created a strong sense of belonging and civic responsibility among the people.

Key Political Institutions

a. Council of Elders

The Council of Elders, led by the **Okpara** (the eldest man in the village), was responsible for decision-making and administering justice. Their authority came from age and wisdom.

b. Age Grade System

Igbo communities were structured into **age grades**, groups of men within the same age range. Each age grade performed specific communal functions like maintenance of roads, law enforcement, and festivals.

c. Title Holders (Ozo Title)

These were respected men who had acquired traditional titles due to wealth, integrity, or service. They played leadership roles and acted as role models.

d. Village Assembly (Ama-ala)

All adult males participated in general meetings to deliberate and make decisions. This system ensured participatory democracy.

e. Diviners and Oracles

Religious leaders interpreted the will of the gods and played a significant role in dispute resolution and moral guidance.

Features of the Igbo Political System

1. **Acephalous (Headless) Structure:** The most striking feature of the Igbo political system was its **acephalous nature**—that is, it lacked a centralised ruler or monarch. There was no king, no emperor, and no singular seat of authority. Each community or village operated independently, with governance being shared among various individuals and institutions. Leadership was diffused, and power rotated through different arms of the society, fostering accountability and preventing tyranny.
2. **Democratic and Participatory Governance:** The Igbo system was highly **democratic**, and decision-making was largely participatory. Every adult male had the right to attend village assemblies (*Ama-ala*) where community matters were discussed. These assemblies functioned as local parliaments, and decisions were made through open debates, consensus, and collective reasoning. This structure nurtured a culture of civic responsibility, freedom of speech, and inclusion in governance.
3. **Decentralisation:** Governance in Igboland was highly decentralised. Each village or group of villages (*clan*) was autonomous, managing its own political, judicial, and economic affairs without interference from neighbouring communities. While towns and villages shared similar customs, no overarching political authority unified them all. This made the system highly flexible and adaptable to local needs.
4. **Role of Age Grades:** The age-grade system (*Ogbo*) was a key organising principle in Igbo society. Citizens were grouped based on age brackets, and each age grade had clearly defined responsibilities. These included road maintenance, community development, conflict resolution, and law enforcement. In times of crisis or conflict, the age grades served as community police and defence units. They were also involved in

planning festivals and promoting discipline among peers. This structure helped to mobilise the population and instil a sense of civic duty.

5. **Religion and Custom as Political Instruments:** Religion was deeply woven into the political fabric of Igbo society. The belief in **deities, ancestors, and the sacredness of traditions** influenced decision-making. **Priests, diviners (Dibia), and oracle custodians** were respected authorities who interpreted the will of the gods and advised on important issues. Before major decisions were made, communities often **consulted oracles** like the famous Arochukwu Oracle to seek spiritual guidance. Customary laws—derived from ancestral traditions—formed the basis of the judicial system.

Comparison Between Yoruba and Igbo Systems

Feature	Yoruba	Igbo
Structure	Centralised, monarchical	Decentralised, republican
Leadership	Alaafin, advised by Oyomesi	Council of Elders, age grades
Succession	Hereditary with approval	Not hereditary; based on age/status
Religious Influence	Strong – Ogboni, divine kingship	Strong – Oracles, diviners
Public Participation	Limited to council chiefs	Broad participation by adult males
Level of Central Authority	High – Oyo Empire ruled provinces	Low – each village autonomous

WAEC/NECO Sample Examination Questions

WAEC 2014 (Q5):

Compare the political organisation of the Yoruba and Igbo people in pre-colonial Nigeria.

NECO 2019 (Q3):

Describe the major features of the Yoruba pre-colonial political system.

Essay Question for Practice:

Explain the role of the age grade system in the Igbo traditional society.



WEEK NINE: COLONIAL ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA

Colonialism

Colonialism refers to the system whereby a powerful country establishes control over a weaker territory, exploits its resources, and imposes its political, economic, social, and cultural systems. Colonialism involves the extension of a nation's sovereignty over territories beyond its borders, usually by settlement, conquest or both.

In the context of Nigeria, colonialism began with the gradual annexation of territories by the British in the 19th century, culminating in the formal establishment of British colonial rule by the early 20th century.

Colonial Administration in Nigeria

The British colonial administration in Nigeria was formalised with the amalgamation of the Northern and Southern Protectorates in 1914 by Lord Frederick Lugard. The administration was primarily aimed at controlling local populations, maintaining law and order, and exploiting resources for the benefit of Britain.

Colonial administration in Nigeria was based on two major principles:

- Centralisation of power in colonial officials (Governors, District Officers, Residents)
- Use of traditional rulers as intermediaries between the colonial government and the local people (especially in the North)

Over time, various systems of administration were introduced by both the **British** and **French** in their respective colonies in Africa, with different strategies and outcomes.

British Colonial Policy in Nigeria

The British operated a system of governance in Nigeria that combined **direct and indirect control**, but is most known for its **Indirect Rule** system.

Features of British Colonial Administration:

- **Centralised hierarchy** led by a British Governor who reported to the Colonial Office in London.
- **Residents and District Officers** were placed in provinces and districts to supervise local affairs.
- **Native Authorities (chiefs, emirs, obas)** served as intermediaries between the colonial government and the local populace.
- **Laws and taxes** were imposed by the British, often with input from traditional rulers.
- The aim was to rule “on the cheap” by using **existing local institutions** instead of deploying large numbers of British administrators.

French Colonial Policy (Assimilation and Association)

In contrast to British Indirect Rule, the **French colonial policy**—though not practised in Nigeria—provides an important comparative perspective.

a. Assimilation:

Assimilation was a French colonial policy that aimed to turn Africans into French citizens by encouraging them to fully adopt French culture, language, laws, and values. It sought to erase African identities in favour of European norms.

b. Association:

When assimilation proved unrealistic, the French adopted the association policy, which allowed Africans to keep their local customs and traditions but placed them under strict French political and economic control. It was a more flexible form of indirect domination.

Key Features of French Colonial Rule:

Centralised Administration:

The French ruled their colonies directly from Paris, with decisions made by colonial

officials. They used fewer traditional rulers compared to the British, preferring to place power in the hands of appointed French-trained administrators.

Emphasis on French Language and Education:

French was the official language of governance, education, and public life. Africans were encouraged—or forced—to abandon their native languages and adopt French culture and values through formal schooling.

French Citizenship for the “Four Communes” of Senegal:

Africans from Saint-Louis, Gorée, Dakar, and Rufisque (the Four Communes) were granted full French citizenship if they accepted French laws and customs. This was part of the assimilation policy.

Undermining of Local Institutions:

Traditional leadership, customs, and political systems were often ignored or replaced. This led to cultural imperialism, as the French imposed their way of life on African societies, weakening indigenous authority structures.

Indirect Rule in Nigeria

Meaning of Indirect Rule

Indirect Rule was a system of administration introduced by Lord Lugard in which the British governed their colonies by **using existing traditional institutions and leaders**. The policy was formalised in Nigeria in the early 20th century and became the hallmark of British colonial administration.

Features of Indirect Rule

Traditional rulers were retained and used as agents of the colonial government:

The British ruled through existing kings, chiefs, and emirs, using them to implement colonial policies instead of replacing them.

Native courts and police were established under the supervision of British officials:

Local law and order were maintained through courts and police set up by the British but operated by traditional authorities under colonial oversight.

The Emir, Oba, or chief collected taxes and administered local affairs on behalf of the British:

These rulers handled local governance and revenue collection, acting as intermediaries between the people and colonial officials.

The British Governor retained ultimate authority:

Although local rulers handled daily administration, the Governor had the final say in all major matters of policy and governance.

Indirect rule was cheap and efficient, as it reduced the need for British personnel:

By using local leaders, the British avoided the cost and complexity of sending many administrators from Britain.

6. Application of Indirect Rule in Nigeria

a. In the North (Hausa/Fulani)

- Highly successful due to the existing **centralised emirate system**.
- The British retained the Emirs, who already had bureaucracies and Islamic law (Sharia).
- Indirect Rule was easily implemented and remained largely intact until independence.

b. In the West (Yoruba)

- Moderately successful due to existing monarchies like the **Oyo Empire**.
- Challenges arose from the influence of **educated elites and Christian converts** who resented the power given to traditional rulers.
- Some communities had multiple rulers or lacked strong kingship, making uniform application difficult.

c. In the East (Igbo)

- Indirect Rule largely **failed** in the East due to the **acephalous (headless) political system**.
- The British introduced **Warrant Chiefs**, many of whom had no legitimacy among the people.
- This led to widespread resistance, notably the **Aba Women's Riot of 1929**, triggered by taxation and abuse of power by warrant chiefs.

Merits of Indirect Rule

- Economical: Reduced administrative costs for the colonial government.
- Utilised existing institutions and customs.
- Reduced resistance in areas where traditional rulers were respected.
- Promoted order and stability, especially in Northern Nigeria.
- Allowed gradual Western influence without immediate cultural disruption.

Demerits of Indirect Rule

- Reinforced autocracy and the power of traditional rulers.
- Suppressed democratic development and limited access to Western education.
- Failed in areas without centralised traditional structures (e.g., among the Igbo).
- Fostered **ethnic and regional divisions**, which later impacted national unity.
- Often manipulated traditional systems to serve colonial interests.

WAEC/NECO Practice Questions

2. Essay Question (NECO 2019):

Explain the concept of Indirect Rule and examine its success and failure in different regions of Nigeria.

3. Essay Question (WAEC 2020):

Discuss the key features of British colonial administration in Nigeria and compare them with the French policy of assimilation.



WEEK TEN: NATIONALISM IN NIGERIA

Nationalism refers to the desire, consciousness, or movement of a people to achieve and maintain political independence, national unity, self-governance, and cultural identity. It is a strong feeling of pride and loyalty that people have towards their country, often leading them to oppose foreign domination and seek self-rule.

In the context of **Nigeria**, nationalism developed as a resistance to British colonial rule. It emerged gradually, starting with cultural and political awareness in the early 20th century, and grew stronger through organised movements, culminating in independence on **1st October 1960**.

Types of Nigerian Nationalism

1. **Cultural Nationalism:**

Early efforts by Nigerian elites to protect and promote African traditions, languages, and values against Western domination.

Example: The founding of the *Lagos Weekly Record* and promotion of Yoruba and Igbo cultural identities.

2. **Political Nationalism:**

Agitation for political rights, representation, constitutional reforms, and eventually independence.

Example: Activities of the Nigerian Youth Movement and the National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (NCNC).

3. **Economic Nationalism:**

Push against foreign economic domination and advocacy for indigenous control of Nigerian resources and businesses.

Example: Protests against discriminatory practices by European companies and campaigns for better wages.

Causes of Nationalism in Nigeria

Several factors contributed to the rise of nationalism in Nigeria:

a. Colonial Oppression and Exploitation

British colonial policies, such as taxation without representation, land expropriation, forced labour, and racial discrimination, created widespread resentment.

b. Introduction of Western Education

Educated Nigerians became aware of democratic ideals and questioned colonial rule. Missionary schools produced elites who would later become nationalist leaders.

c. Formation of Political and Cultural Associations

Groups like the *Nigerian Youth Movement (NYM)*, *Egbe Omo Oduduwa*, and *Ibo State Union* created platforms for mobilisation and awareness.

d. Impact of the World Wars

Nigerians who fought in **World War I and II** returned with a new sense of equality and were inspired by global anti-colonial movements.

e. Economic Exploitation

Foreign firms monopolised commerce and discriminated against Africans, prompting agitation for economic self-determination.

f. Influence of Pan-Africanism and Black Consciousness

Global movements led by figures like **Marcus Garvey** and **Kwame Nkrumah** inspired Nigerians to fight colonialism.

g. Media and Newspapers

Nigerian-owned newspapers such as the *West African Pilot* (founded by Nnamdi Azikiwe) were critical in spreading nationalist ideas and consciousness.

h. Constitutional Reforms

Gradual reforms such as the **Clifford Constitution (1922)**, which allowed limited African participation in politics, encouraged political engagement and activism.

The journey to Nigeria's independence was shaped by the efforts of prominent nationalist leaders who fought against colonial rule through political activism, education, journalism, and grassroots mobilisation. These individuals came from different parts of the country but were united by a desire for self-governance and national unity.

1. Herbert Macaulay (1864–1946)

Regarded as the **Father of Nigerian Nationalism**, Macaulay used his writings and political influence to oppose colonial exploitation and defend traditional rulers. He founded the **Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP)** in 1923, giving Nigerians their first experience with party politics. He was also instrumental in laying the foundation for later nationalist movements.

2. Nnamdi Azikiwe (1904–1996)

Popularly known as “Zik”, Azikiwe promoted nationalism through his newspaper, the **West African Pilot**. He co-founded the NCNC and advocated for African unity, self-determination, and democratic governance. He later became Nigeria's **first President** in 1963.

3. Obafemi Awolowo (1909–1987)

A strong advocate of **federalism** and **free education**, Awolowo founded the **Action Group (AG)** and played a major role in constitutional negotiations. As Premier of Western Nigeria, he introduced progressive policies that inspired development and political consciousness.

4. Ahmadu Bello (1909–1966)

As leader of the **Northern People's Congress (NPC)** and Premier of Northern Nigeria, Bello championed the interests of the North while promoting unity and gradual self-rule. He believed in preserving traditional values alongside modern governance.

5. Anthony Enahoro

A journalist and politician, Enahoro is famous for moving the **first motion for Nigeria's independence** in 1953. Though the motion was initially rejected, it intensified nationalist efforts and highlighted the urgency for self-rule.

Effects of Nationalism in Nigeria

a. Growth of Political Parties

Nationalist movements gave rise to parties like the NCNC, NPC, and AG, which played vital roles in the struggle for independence.

b. Increased Political Awareness

More Nigerians became involved in politics and demanded greater representation and participation in governance.

c. Development of the Media

Newspapers and other media became powerful tools for sensitising the public and opposing colonial policies.

d. Constitutional Reforms and Self-Government

Nationalist pressure led to the introduction of progressive constitutions:

- **Clifford Constitution (1922)**
- **Richards Constitution (1946)**
- **Macpherson Constitution (1951)**
- **Lyttleton Constitution (1954)**

These reforms led to **internal self-government in 1957** and full independence on **1st October 1960**.

e. Unity and Collaboration among Regions

Despite ethnic and regional differences, nationalists worked together towards a common goal of independence.

f. Emergence of Indigenous Leadership

Colonial administrators were gradually replaced by Nigerians in leadership and civil service positions.

Challenges Faced by Nigerian Nationalists

The nationalist movement in Nigeria encountered several difficulties that slowed the path to independence and weakened collective action. These challenges include:

1. Ethnic and Regional Rivalries:

Cooperation among nationalist leaders was often limited due to deep-seated ethnic and regional differences. Leaders from the North, East, and West sometimes prioritised their ethnic or regional interests over national unity, leading to fragmentation within the movement.

2. Differences in Approach (Gradualism vs. Immediate Independence):

Some nationalists, especially from the South, demanded immediate self-government, while others, particularly from the North, preferred a gradual transition to independence. This divergence in opinion weakened consensus and slowed the struggle.

3. Colonial Divide-and-Rule Tactics:

The British colonial administration deliberately used divide-and-rule strategies to keep the regions and ethnic groups suspicious of one another. By doing so, they reduced the ability of nationalists to form a united front.

4. Lack of Access to Resources and Platforms for Mobilisation:

Many nationalists struggled with limited access to funding, media coverage, and communication infrastructure. These constraints made it difficult to mobilise mass support, especially in rural areas where political awareness was low.

WAEC/NECO Past Questions

WAEC 2022 – Essay Question:

Discuss five causes of nationalism in Nigeria and highlight the contributions of any two nationalist leaders.



